



The Key Teachings of
RICHARD BAXTER



*There remaineth therefore
a rest to the people of God.*

HEBREWS 4:9

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Published by Ochorus.

This book is an independent work of exposition, summary and appreciation. All descriptions of Baxter's teaching are the present author's own summaries, and his seventeenth-century English has been rendered into modern prose throughout rather than quoted. Where his works are named, they are named for the reader's further study. Baxter's own writings are in the public domain and are widely available at no cost; readers are warmly encouraged to go to them directly.

Unless otherwise indicated, all Scripture quotations are taken from the Authorised (King James) Version, which was the Bible of Baxter's pulpit.

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Introduction

There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God.

HEBREWS 4:9

There is a line about preaching that has been quoted in more sermons than almost any other in the English language. Its author said he preached as a man who could never be sure of preaching again, and as a dying man to dying men.

Most people who repeat it could not tell you who said it. It was Richard Baxter, and it was not a rhetorical flourish. He wrote it as a plain description of his own circumstances. He was ill for most of his adult life, expected to die young for about fifty years, and buried the town he loved under an Act of Parliament. The urgency in his preaching was not manufactured. He genuinely did not expect to be there the following week.

A parish that changed

He is remembered for two things, and they belong together.

The first is what happened at Kidderminster, a rough Worcestershire weaving town where he arrived in 1641 to find, by his own account, a parish largely ignorant of the gospel and given to drink. When he left, some twenty years later, the place had been transformed — so thoroughly that visitors came to see it, and the change was still spoken of a century afterwards. Whole streets sang psalms on their way home from work. He had to build galleries in the church five times.

The second is how he did it, because the method was startlingly unromantic. He preached twice a week. And he set aside two full days every week to sit down with families in his parish, one household at a time, and go through the Christian faith with them personally — about fourteen families a week, some eight hundred families a year. He did it with his assistant, methodically, for years.

That is the whole secret, and it is why his book on ministry has never gone out of print.

The other half of him

But Baxter is not merely the patron saint of diligent pastors, and a book that presented him that way would miss what he actually cared about.

His most famous work is about heaven. *The Saints' Everlasting Rest* was written in 1647, at thirty-one, while he lay gravely ill far from home

and from his books, fully expecting to die. He wrote it, he said, for himself — a dying man's meditations on where he was going. It became one of the best-loved books of its century, and it turned him from a country minister into a household name.

The two halves explain each other. Baxter worked as he did because of where he believed people were going. He gave himself to catechising illiterate weavers because he thought each of them would exist for ever. Take away the rest and the labour makes no sense; take away the labour and the rest becomes sentiment.

How this book is arranged

Eighteen short chapters set out his teaching, beginning with the breadth of spirit that made him unusual, moving through his doctrine of heaven and the practice of heavenly meditation, then to conversion and justification, then to the pastoral work for which he is best known, then to the ordinary Christian disciplines — family religion, self-examination, the use of time — and finally to suffering, unity and dying well.

Each chapter ends with application points and a prayer. Baxter would have approved and probably added more. He had an almost impatient conviction that truth which stops short of practice is worse than useless, and his great practical work — *A Christian Directory* — consists of nearly a million words of direct instruction on how to live.

Read one chapter a day, or one a week. Stop at the application points. Pray the prayer, or better, pray your own.

One note on the text. Baxter wrote a seventeenth-century English that many readers find heavy going. Throughout this book his teaching is summarised in modern prose rather than quoted, so that the argument comes through without the thicket. Readers who go on to the originals should be warned that the sentences are long and the pace is unhurried; that is the century, not the man.

One more thing must be said at the outset, and it is better said plainly.

This is not a book of hero-worship, and Baxter is a particularly poor candidate for it.

He was contentious. He spent an extraordinary proportion of his life in controversy — with bishops, with Independents, with Quakers, with Antinomians, with fellow Presbyterians — and he could not let an argument alone. He wrote around a hundred and forty books, many of them polemical, and he admitted late in life that he had written too much, too quickly, and too sharply.

His doctrine of justification was widely judged to be a departure from the Reformed teaching of his own party, and the controversy over it

outlived him by two centuries. Chapter six sets out what he held and where the objections lie. The reader should weigh it carefully rather than accept it on the strength of his other virtues.

And his political judgment was, by his own reckoning, imperfect. He served as a chaplain in the parliamentary army and afterwards regretted much of what that side did. He helped bring about the Restoration and was then ejected by it. He was, as one modern historian has put it, a man who managed to fall out with almost every party in church and state, generally on principle and sometimes on temperament.

Baxter knew this about himself. One of the most valuable things he ever wrote is a passage in his autobiography reviewing how his mind had changed with age: he had grown less confident of his own judgment, less impressed by his own learning, more charitable towards those who differed from him, and more convinced that the essentials of Christianity are fewer and plainer than controversialists suppose. It is a remarkable piece of self-knowledge from a man who had spent decades arguing.

So the counsel of this book is the counsel of Scripture: *Prove all things; hold fast that which is good* (1 Thessalonians 5:21). Where Baxter is faithful — and on the work of the ministry, the reality of heaven, the duty of personal instruction and the breadth of Christian charity, he is faithful indeed — receive it gladly. Where he presses beyond what is written, mark it, set it aside, and lose nothing.

A final word about the reader this book assumes.

Baxter wrote for English weavers in a market town during a civil war, and for ministers scattered across a country tearing itself apart over church order. He is read now in places he never heard of, by Christians whose circumstances have nothing in common with his.

The reason is that he wrote about what does not change: that people die, that they must be told the truth before they do, that ministers are answerable for those in their care, and that the ordinary household is where religion is either made real or quietly abandoned.

Those matters are already waiting wherever this book is opened, and into whatever language it is carried.

A Dying Man to Dying Men

I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith.

2 TIMOTHY 4:7

A badly educated boy. Richard Baxter was born on the twelfth of November, 1615, at Rowton in Shropshire, in his maternal grandfather's house. His parents were Richard and Beatrice Baxter; his father had gambled away much of the family's small estate before his conversion, and money was tight.

His education was, by his own bitter account, wretched. The village had a succession of teachers who were ignorant, drunk, or both. He never went to university — a fact that his opponents used against him all his life and that he never entirely got over.

What he had instead was an appetite. He read everything he could obtain, taught himself theology, philosophy and medicine, and became one of the most learned men in England by sheer application. He was later described as the chief of the English Protestant schoolmen, which is a considerable thing to say of a man with no degree.

His conversion came through books rather than preaching — a devotional volume that came into the house by accident, and afterwards the writings of the English Puritans. He dated his real awakening from that reading and never forgot it, which is one reason he spent the rest of his life pressing books into people's hands.

Kidderminster. He was ordained deacon by the Bishop of Worcester in Advent 1638, kept a school at Dudley, and served briefly as curate at Bridgnorth.

In 1641 he was invited to Kidderminster, a weaving town of some two thousand people in Worcestershire. The previous incumbent was reportedly incompetent and the parish neglected. Baxter was twenty-five.

Then the country collapsed into civil war. He left the town, served as chaplain to the garrison at Coventry and afterwards to Colonel Whalley's regiment in the New Model Army, where he spent his energies arguing against the sectarian opinions spreading among the soldiers. He came to regret a good deal about those years.

In 1647 his health broke completely. He was taken in by friends at Rouse Lench, far from his library, and lay for months expecting to die.

It was there, with almost no books to consult, that he wrote the bulk of *The Saints' Everlasting Rest*.

He did not die. He returned to Kidderminster in 1647 as vicar, and stayed fourteen years.

What he did there. The ministry at Kidderminster became the most celebrated parish work in English history, and it is worth stating what it actually consisted of.

He preached twice weekly, plainly, aiming at the conscience rather than at admiration. He and his assistant then devoted two whole days each week to personal instruction — summoning the families of the parish in turn, sitting down with each household, examining what they understood of the Christian faith, and teaching them individually. They worked through roughly fourteen families a week and covered the parish in a year.

He organised the local ministers into an association that crossed the Presbyterian, Independent and Episcopalian divisions, so that discipline and catechising could be practised in common. He wrote continuously. He gave away a large part of a modest income.

And the town changed. On his arrival, he reckoned, perhaps one family in a street showed any serious religion; when he left, there were streets where nearly every family did. He was careful to add that he claimed no credit for it and could name plenty of towns where better men had laboured and seen nothing.

Restoration and ejection. The monarchy was restored in 1660, and Baxter — who had worked for it — went to London as one of the king's chaplains. He was offered the bishopric of Hereford and declined it. He asked for nothing except permission to return to Kidderminster, and was refused.

At the Savoy Conference in 1661 he was the principal spokesman for the moderate Puritan party, and drew up a revised liturgy in a fortnight in the hope of a settlement broad enough to hold the moderates inside the national church. The hope was disappointed; there was no real appetite for compromise on the other side.

The Act of Uniformity took effect on the twenty-fourth of August, 1662. Around two thousand ministers who could not subscribe were ejected from their livings on that day. Baxter, seeing what was coming, had already preached his farewell sermon in London the previous May.

He was forty-six, and he never held a parish again.

Margaret. In September 1662, weeks after the ejection, he married Margaret Charlton. He was forty-seven and she was twenty-six, and the marriage astonished everyone, including a good many people who

had assumed he would never marry at all.

By every account it was extraordinarily happy. She was intelligent, decisive and devout, managed their affairs, and pressed him into ventures he would not have attempted alone. They lived through nineteen years of harassment, fines and forced removals together.

She died in 1681, aged forty-five. Baxter, heartbroken, wrote an account of her life and character within weeks. It is one of the most affecting things in seventeenth-century English — a widower's honest portrait of a woman he plainly considered his superior in several respects, published while the grief was raw.

Persecution. The years after 1662 were spent in and around London under a legal regime designed to make nonconformist ministry impossible. Baxter was harassed continually: forbidden to preach, fined, his goods distrained, his books seized, and moved from lodging to lodging.

He was imprisoned briefly in 1669 for holding a conventicle. The serious blow came in 1685, when he was seventy and infirm. He was charged with sedition for supposed reflections on the bishops in his *Paraphrase on the New Testament*, and tried before Lord Chief Justice Jeffreys.

The trial was a disgrace. Jeffreys abused him from the bench, called him an old rogue who had poisoned the world with his Kidderminster doctrine, and would not let his counsel speak. Baxter was fined a sum he could not pay and imprisoned for some twenty-one months in Southwark.

He was released in 1686, and lived to see the Toleration Act of 1689 give nonconformists legal breathing room at last.

The end. His last years were spent in Charterhouse Square in London, still writing, still preaching when permitted, and in continual pain from ailments he had catalogued with a physician's precision for half a century.

He died on the eighth of December, 1691, aged seventy-six. Asked near the end how he was, he is said to have answered that he was almost well.

He left around a hundred and forty published works, a parish that remembered him for generations, a manual of pastoral ministry that is still set for theological students, and a book about heaven written by a man who had spent fifty years expecting to arrive there shortly.

A Mere Christian

*Now this I say, that every one of you saith, I am of Paul; and I of Apollos
...Is Christ divided?*

1 CORINTHIANS 1:12–13

In 1680, worn down by forty years of being told which party he belonged to, Baxter wrote a sentence that has outlived nearly everything else he published.

He said he was a Christian — a mere Christian — of no other religion, and that he would not be labelled by any narrower name.

Nearly three centuries later C. S. Lewis borrowed the phrase for a book, and acknowledged where he had found it. Most people who use it now have no idea it began with a persecuted Puritan who could not get anybody to believe he was not a party man.

A man nobody could place

Baxter's difficulty was that he genuinely did not fit.

He was called a Presbyterian, and he was not one in any strict sense; he believed in a moderate episcopacy of the kind Archbishop Ussher had proposed. He was ejected as a Nonconformist, and he wanted to remain in the national church and worked hard to make that possible. He served the parliamentary cause and then laboured for the king's restoration. He was attacked by strict Calvinists for softening the doctrine of the atonement, and by Arminians for holding to election, and by Antinomians for insisting on obedience, and by the Quakers for practically everything.

He was, in other words, in trouble with everyone, and it was not accidental. He held that the essentials of Christianity are fewer and clearer than controversialists suppose, and that most of what divides believers belongs to a second rank of matters on which good men will differ until the Lord returns.

*There is one body, and one Spirit, even as ye are called in one hope of your calling;
one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all.*

EPHESIANS 4:4–6

Baxter's method was to ask what a person must believe and do to be saved, and to treat that as the ground of fellowship — refusing to make agreement on anything further a condition of receiving a brother.

Necessary things, doubtful things

The formula usually attached to his name is worth quoting accurately, and also worth attributing accurately, since he is regularly given credit for it: in necessary things unity, in doubtful things liberty, in all things charity.

The saying did not originate with Baxter. It appears to come from a German Lutheran writer of the previous generation, Rupertus Melde-nius, and has been misattributed to Augustine for centuries. What Baxter did was press it into English use and try to live by it, which is harder than coining it.

The practical difficulty, as he knew perfectly well, is that everyone agrees with the formula and nobody agrees about which things go in which column. Baxter's answer was to work from the apostolic summaries — the Creed, the Lord's Prayer, the Ten Commandments — and to argue that what the church had required of converts in the first centuries was a reasonable measure of what was strictly necessary now.

Let us therefore, as many as be perfect, be thus minded: and if in any thing ye be otherwise minded, God shall reveal even this unto you. Nevertheless, whereto we have already attained, let us walk by the same rule.

PHILIPPIANS 3:15–16

That is Paul contemplating disagreement among mature believers, declining to force the issue, and telling them to get on together on the basis of what they already share.

Unity that was actually practised

Baxter's irenicism was not merely a sentiment expressed in prefaces. At Kidderminster he organised the ministers of the county into an association that deliberately crossed the party lines — Presbyterians, Independents and Episcopalians agreeing to co-operate in discipline, catechising and mutual counsel, while leaving their disagreements unresolved.

It worked, locally and for a time, and other counties copied it. That is more than most ecumenical schemes achieve, and it was achieved by a man who had strong opinions on every one of the questions being set aside.

Endeavouring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

EPHESIANS 4:3

Note the verb. Not *create* the unity — *keep* it. It already exists; our task is to avoid destroying it.

The change he noticed in himself

The most valuable thing Baxter wrote on this subject is a passage of self-examination in his autobiography, in which he sets out how his mind

had altered between youth and age.

He had become, he said, less confident of his own judgment and more aware of how much he did not know. He was less impressed by clever men and more impressed by holy ones. He had come to think the differences between godly Christians smaller, and the difference between the godly and the ungodly larger, than he once supposed. He was slower to condemn, quicker to allow for honest error, and far more concerned with the few great truths than with the many disputed ones.

It is a remarkable inventory from a man who had spent his working life in controversy, and it suggests that he learned something from all that arguing which the arguing itself could not teach him.

The limit

One caution, because breadth can become emptiness.

Baxter was not indifferent to doctrine, and it would be a serious misunderstanding to enlist him for the view that beliefs do not much matter. He wrote enormous volumes defending positions he thought vital, and he went to prison rather than subscribe to terms he judged false. His charity was not vagueness; it was a considered judgment about which truths are load-bearing.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:21

The test he leaves us is uncomfortably specific. Not *do you approve of unity?* — everyone does. But: name the group of Christians you find hardest to take seriously, and ask whether the thing dividing you belongs in the first column or the second.

A practical measure

The obvious objection to Baxter's programme is that everyone claims to distinguish essentials from indifferent things, and no two people draw the line in the same place. He was aware of this, and he offered a working measure.

His proposal was to look at what the church had actually required of converts in its earliest centuries. Before the great confessions, before the councils, before the divisions of the Reformation, a person was received on the basis of a short summary of faith, an undertaking of obedience, and baptism.

From this he built his three-part standard: the Apostles' Creed for what must be believed, the Ten Commandments for what must be obeyed, and the Lord's Prayer for what must be desired. Believe, obey, desire — and if a person holds these sincerely, Baxter argued, we have no warrant to exclude him from Christian fellowship whatever else he

may get wrong.

That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised him from the dead, thou shalt be saved.

ROMANS 10:9

It is not a perfect instrument, and Baxter did not claim it was. Heresies have been held by people who could recite the Creed. But it has one considerable virtue: it is short, it is ancient, and it belongs to no party. Nobody can accuse it of having been designed to include his friends and exclude his opponents.

The discipline it imposes is worth attempting. Take the doctrine you are currently prepared to divide over, and ask where it appears in those three summaries. If it does not, it may still be true and important — but you have learned something about which column it belongs in.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Write out what you consider genuinely necessary to be a Christian. Keep the list short. Then notice how much of what you argue about is not on it.
2. Name the group of believers you least respect. Ask honestly whether the disagreement is essential or merely tribal.
3. Do something practical this month with Christians outside your own tradition — pray, serve, or give together.
4. Review, as Baxter did, how your mind has changed in ten years. If it has not changed at all, that is worth examining.
5. Guard the limit. Breadth is not indifference; be able to say what you would go to prison for.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have taken a narrower name than Christian and defended it as though it were the gospel.

Show me which of my convictions are load-bearing and which are merely mine. Give me the honesty to tell the difference, and the courage to hold the first without contempt for those who differ on the second.

Make me less impressed by cleverness and more impressed by holiness. Slow me down before I condemn.

Let me keep the unity You have already made, and let me not be the one who breaks it. Amen.

The Saints' Everlasting Rest

There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God.

HEBREWS 4:9

In 1647 Baxter was thirty-one years old and dying, or so everyone including himself believed. He had collapsed after two years as an army chaplain, was taken in by friends at a country house a long way from his library, and lay for months with almost no books to consult.

He decided to spend what he assumed were his last months thinking about where he was going, and to write down what he thought. The result was *The Saints' Everlasting Rest*, and it made him famous across England.

He recovered, and lived another forty-four years. The book he wrote for his own deathbed was read at thousands of other people's.

What rest means

Baxter began by defining the word, because it is easily sentimentalised.

Rest is not idleness. The heavenly rest, as he expounded it, has two sides: a ceasing from what has wearied us, and an entering into the enjoyment of what we were made for. It is the end of labour and the beginning of possession.

Blessed are the dead which die in the Lord ...that they may rest from their labours; and their works do follow them.

REVELATION 14:13

The negative side is easy to state, and Baxter, in constant pain, stated it with feeling. There will be an end of sin — not merely of its guilt, which is already dealt with, but of its presence in us. An end of sorrow, of illness, of temptation, of persecution, of the fear of death, and of the sight of God's church divided and harassed.

And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain.

REVELATION 21:4

The positive side

But Baxter was impatient with a heaven described chiefly by what will be absent. The substance of the rest, he insisted, is God Himself.

He set it out under three heads, corresponding to the three great faculties of the soul.

There will be perfect **knowledge**. Every believer who has ever struggled with the obscurity of Scripture, the silence of providence, or the reasons for his own suffering will have the answer — not as an argument, but by sight.

For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

There will be perfect **love**. Baxter thought this the heart of it. The faculty we have used most poorly, spending it on things that could not repay it, will at last have an object worthy of the whole of it, and nothing in us will hold back.

And there will be perfect **joy**, which follows from the other two, since joy is what happens when a soul knows and loves what deserves it.

Thou wilt shew me the path of life: in thy presence is fulness of joy; at thy right hand there are pleasures for evermore.

PSALM 16:11

Rest with a Person

The organising idea is that heaven is not a place we enjoy but a Person we see.

Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.

1 JOHN 3:2

Baxter drew out the sequence in that verse. Seeing produces likeness. The transformation we have been labouring at all our lives, with such partial success, will be accomplished instantly and completely by the sight of Christ.

This is why he regarded a self-centred picture of heaven — reunion with the family, relief from trouble, the crown and the harp — as true but drastically inadequate. Those things are real. They are not the point. A believer whose hope of heaven could be satisfied by comfort and company has not yet understood what he is hoping for.

Why he wrote it

One more thing, and it explains the book's tone.

Baxter did not write *The Saints' Everlasting Rest* as a work of speculative theology, and it contains very little curiosity about the mechanics of the next world. He wrote it as a practical remedy for a specific disease, which he considered nearly universal among Christians: that we believe in heaven and never think about it.

The consequence, he argued, is a religion of dutiful misery. A believer who never contemplates his destination finds obedience burden-

some, suffering intolerable, and death terrifying — not because his doctrine is wrong but because he has left the best part of it unused. The remedy is the subject of the next chapter.

There is a question worth carrying out of this one, and it is a fair test of whether the doctrine has become real.

If heaven consisted of everything you currently associate with it — the absence of pain, the reunion, the rest — but God Himself were somehow not there, would you still want to go?

A rest we enter together

There is a dimension of the heavenly rest that Baxter felt more keenly than most writers on the subject, and it grew directly out of his circumstances.

He spent his life watching the church of England tear itself apart. He was ejected by one side and distrusted by the other. He worked for forty years on schemes of reconciliation that came to nothing. Every party he tried to unite concluded that he belonged to the opposition.

So when he wrote about heaven, the ending of division was not a minor item on the list. It was near the centre.

But ye are come unto mount Sion, and unto the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and to an innumerable company of angels, to the general assembly and church of the firstborn.

HEBREWS 12:22–23

The general assembly. One gathering, undivided, containing all of them — the parties that would not sit at the same table, the men who wrote against each other, the traditions that anathematised one another. Baxter found this an extraordinary comfort, and also a rebuke.

The rebuke is the useful part. If we shall spend eternity in the unbroken company of Christians we currently cannot be in a room with, then our present divisions are temporary in a way our theology admits and our behaviour denies.

That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us.

JOHN 17:21

Baxter's practical suggestion was to think about heaven whenever a church quarrel becomes bitter, and to ask how the matter will look from there. He found it shortened a good many disputes, though not, he admitted, all of his own.

1. Write down what you actually picture when you think of heaven. Notice how much of it is about you.
2. Take 1 John 3:2 and dwell on the sequence: seeing produces likeness. That is the mechanism of the change you have been labouring at.
3. Name the thing in your life that most needs the answer only heaven will give. Bring it to God as something to be waited for rather than solved.
4. Ask whether your religion has become dutiful. If so, consider whether you have left your destination unused.
5. Answer the question above honestly. If God were not there, would you still want it?

A PRAYER

Father, I believe in heaven and I almost never think about it, and my religion has grown heavy in consequence.

Forgive me for a hope so small that it could be satisfied by comfort and company. You are the rest. Not the absence of my troubles — Yourself.

Teach me what I am waiting for. Let the thought of seeing You do in me what my own labour has never managed.

And when the pain and the confusion and the divisions of Your church weigh on me, remind me that there remains a rest for Your people, and that I am on my way to it. Amen.

Heavenly Contemplation

If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above ...Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth.

COLOSSIANS 3:1-2

The last part of *The Saints' Everlasting Rest* is the part Baxter cared about most, and it is the reason the book was so widely used. Having spent several hundred pages describing heaven, he turns and asks a practical question: how does a Christian actually think about it?

His answer is a discipline he called heavenly contemplation, and he set it out with the thoroughness of a man giving directions to a stranger in an unfamiliar town.

Why it must be deliberate

His starting observation is that this does not happen by itself.

Believers assume that if they hold the doctrine, the comfort of it will be available when required — at a graveside, or in a crisis. Baxter's experience was the reverse. The mind does not go to heaven of its own accord; it goes to whatever it has been trained on, which is generally money, work, grievances and the immediate future. A truth we have never dwelt on will not be there when we reach for it.

So he prescribed a set exercise, at a set time, on purpose.

While we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen: for the things which are seen are temporal; but the things which are not seen are eternal.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:18

Look is an active verb. The unseen does not force itself on our attention; it must be looked at.

The practicalities

Baxter was almost comically practical about the arrangements, and it is the most useful part of the whole treatment.

Fix a time. He recommended daily if possible, and at least weekly for those who could not manage it — and he preferred a set hour, because occasional intentions evaporate. Sunday afternoons and evenings he thought particularly suitable.

Choose the place. Somewhere quiet, free of interruption. Baxter himself liked to walk in the fields towards evening, and thought open air and solitude helped more than a closed room.

Come with the heart free. He advised choosing a time when the mind is not fresh from a quarrel or heavy with business, since a soul in that condition cannot lift.

Take a text or a scene, rather than trying to think about heaven in general. Vagueness defeats meditation. Begin with a specific promise, a specific description in Revelation, a specific attribute of God.

Consideration, and then the affections

The structure of the exercise itself has two stages, and Baxter was insistent that most people stop after the first.

The first stage is **consideration** — the deliberate work of the understanding. Turn the truth over. Ask what it means, what it implies, what it is worth. Compare heaven with what you are currently pursuing. Reason from what God has already done to what He has promised to do.

The second stage is the **engagement of the affections**, and this is the point of the whole thing. Consideration is the bellows; the affections are the fire. Having thought about the truth, deliberately stir yourself to love it, long for it, hope in it, rejoice in it and grieve that you have neglected it.

Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside thee.

PSALM 73:25

Baxter observed that this is exactly what the psalmists do, and he made much of the practice of **soliloquy** — preaching to one's own soul. The Psalms are full of it: *Why art thou cast down, O my soul?* A man may plead with himself as he would with another, and Baxter thought most Christians would be transformed if they addressed themselves half as directly as they address other people.

The exercise ends in **conversation with God** — the meditation turning naturally into prayer, which is where it was always heading.

Two cautions

First, this can become a technique, and a technique can become a burden. Baxter was writing directions, not laying down a law, and a believer who ends up measuring his spirituality by how well the exercise went has misused it.

Second — and this matters — some people cannot do this, and it is not their fault. Those weighed down by grief, exhaustion or the illness of mind Baxter called melancholy may find that sustained meditation makes them worse rather than better. He knew this and said so elsewhere, and we shall come to his counsel on it in a later chapter. Such a person should not conclude that heaven is closed to him because his

mind will not settle.

The most useful thing in this chapter is also the smallest. Fix a time this week — twenty minutes will do — and take one promise about the world to come, and think about it until you feel something.

That last clause is the whole discipline. Most of us stop at understanding, and wonder why the truth never warms us.

Using what you know

One of Baxter's more unusual directions concerns the use of the imagination, and it needs stating carefully because it is easily misunderstood.

He observed that the mind cannot conceive of what it has never encountered. We have no direct experience of heaven, and so an instruction to think about it frequently produces a blank. His remedy was to reason upward from things we do know.

Take the deepest joy you have experienced — a reunion, a recovery, a burden lifted, the first hour of a holiday after a hard year — and then consider that this is a shadow cast by something greater, produced by a God who invented joy and has not exhausted His stock.

But as it is written, Eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither have entered into the heart of man, the things which God hath prepared for them that love him.

1 CORINTHIANS 2:9

Baxter used the same method with relief from suffering. A person who has been in long pain knows something about what the cessation of pain will feel like, and may reason from the lesser to the greater.

Two cautions, which he supplied himself.

This is comparison, not construction. We are reasoning from Scripture's own images to what they signify, not inventing a heaven to our own taste. The moment the exercise starts producing a place shaped by our preferences rather than by God's presence, it has gone wrong.

And it is a help for the affections, not a source of doctrine. Nothing learned by this method may be taught as fact. Scripture governs, and where it is silent we are content not to know.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Fix a specific time and place this week for one deliberate meditation on heaven. Twenty minutes is enough to begin.
2. Take one concrete promise rather than the subject in general. Vagueness defeats meditation.
3. Do not stop at understanding. Having thought, deliberately stir your affections — longing, joy, grief at your own neglect.

4. Try soliloquy. Address your own soul aloud as you would address a friend who needed persuading.
5. If your mind will not settle because of grief or exhaustion, do not force it or condemn yourself. Read chapter fifteen instead.

A PRAYER

Lord, my mind goes wherever it has been trained to go, and I have trained it on money, work and grievances.

Teach me to look at what is unseen. Not occasionally, when trouble drives me to it, but deliberately, at a set hour, as a discipline.

Take me past understanding into desire. Let me not merely think about the rest You have promised, but long for it.

And where my heart is too heavy to rise, be gentle with me, and lift it Yourself. Amen.

A Call to the Unconverted

Turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, O house of Israel?

EZEKIEL 33:11

In 1658 Baxter published a small book that outsold almost everything else he wrote. *A Call to the Unconverted* was addressed not to ministers or to mature believers but to people sitting in church every week who had never, so far as he could tell, been converted at all.

It went through edition after edition, was translated into several languages within his lifetime, and Baxter received reports of conversions from it for the rest of his life — including from places he had never visited.

The verse that governs it

The whole book is an exposition of one verse, and the choice tells us a great deal about his instincts.

Say unto them, As I live, saith the Lord God, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; but that the wicked turn from his way and live.

EZEKIEL 33:11

Baxter fastened on three things in it.

God swears. *As I live* is an oath, and Baxter asked what it means that God should take an oath about His own disposition towards sinners. It means the matter has been disputed, and that God is answering the charge.

God denies taking pleasure in their ruin. Baxter thought this the most commonly disbelieved sentence in Scripture — not intellectually denied, but practically disbelieved by people who imagine that God is looking for a reason to condemn them and will not be sorry when He finds one.

And God pleads. The doubling — *turn ye, turn ye* — is the language of someone who will not take silence for an answer.

Why will ye die?

The refrain of the book is the question at the end of the verse, and Baxter turned it over and over, because he regarded it as unanswerable.

Nobody has a reason. The man who will not turn cannot produce an account of himself that would survive five minutes of honest examina-

tion. He is not choosing hell; he is postponing the subject, which comes to the same thing in the end.

Baxter's method throughout is to reason with the reader rather than to work on him. He anticipates objections and answers them. He asks what the reader is gaining by delay, what he expects to be different next year, whether he supposes he will have more inclination then or less, and what he intends to say when asked to account for the delay.

Behold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation.

2 CORINTHIANS 6:2

Earnestness without manipulation

There is a distinction here worth noticing, because evangelistic urgency has a long history of going wrong.

Baxter is enormously earnest. He pleads; he repeats himself; he presses the reader with the shortness of life and the certainty of judgment. And he does it entirely by argument and appeal to the conscience. There is no working of the emotions for their own sake, no engineered crisis, no technique for producing a response in a meeting.

The difference matters. Manipulation produces decisions that dissolve within a month, and it leaves the manipulated person harder than before, because he has now been inoculated. Baxter aimed at the understanding and the conscience, trusting that if a man genuinely saw his situation he would act.

Knowing therefore the terror of the Lord, we persuade men.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:11

Persuade is the word. It assumes a mind that can be reached.

Written for people who could not read it

One detail about the book's circulation is worth recording, because it explains Baxter's whole approach to publishing.

He wrote deliberately in plain language for poor readers, kept the price low, and gave copies away in quantity. He urged wealthy Christians to buy stocks of such books and distribute them, and he did the same himself with a good deal of his own income.

In a parish where many could not read at all, he expected the literate to read aloud to the household. The book is written to be heard as much as read — the sentences are direct, the arguments repeat, and the address is personal throughout.

How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard?

ROMANS 10:14

A note on his doctrine here

Readers acquainted with the debates of Baxter's century will notice that this book leans on the universality of the gospel call, and that Baxter defends the sincerity of God's offer to all who hear it with more warmth than some of his strictly Calvinist contemporaries thought proper.

He held a modified position on the extent of the atonement, and it shaped his evangelism. We shall come to the controversy in chapter six. It is enough here to say that whatever one concludes about the theology, Baxter's practice is the one the New Testament models: a universal, urgent, sincere call to every hearer, without qualification and without hedging.

There is an application of this chapter that most readers will want to avoid, and it is the obvious one.

You know someone who is not converted. You see them regularly. You have never raised it, because the moment never seems right and you do not want to damage the relationship.

Baxter's question is not whether the moment is right. It is what you will say about the delay.

What delay actually is

Baxter devoted considerable space to the commonest response his book met, which was not rejection but postponement.

Almost nobody, he observed, decides against Christ. What people do is agree in principle and defer in practice — intending to attend to the matter later, when life is less pressing, when the children are older, when the business is settled.

He regarded this as the most dangerous condition a person can be in, precisely because it feels reasonable and produces no alarm.

And as he reasoned of righteousness, temperance, and judgment to come, Felix trembled, and answered, Go thy way for this time; when I have a convenient season, I will call for thee.

ACTS 24:25

Felix is the pattern. He was moved — he trembled — and he postponed, and so far as the record goes the convenient season never arrived.

Baxter's argument against delay ran on three lines.

You have no lease on the time. The assumption that the matter can be attended to later depends on a future nobody has been promised.

You will not be more inclined then. Every year of postponement makes the thing harder, not easier, because habits set and consciences grow quieter.

But exhort one another daily, while it is called To day; lest any of you be hardened through the deceitfulness of sin.

HEBREWS 3:13

And you are, in the meantime, losing everything the delay costs — the peace, the usefulness, the years that might have been spent well.

His conclusion was blunt. A man who intends to turn eventually has already conceded the argument and is merely haggling over the date, which is a remarkably poor thing to be doing with a life.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name one person you see regularly who, so far as you can tell, is not converted. Write the name down.
2. Ask yourself Baxter's own question about your silence: what are you gaining by the delay, and what do you expect to be different next year?
3. If you have been putting off your own turning to God, stop postponing. Nobody has a reason that survives examination.
4. Aim at the conscience, not the emotions. Reason with people; do not work on them.
5. Buy a plain, sound Christian book and give it away. It was one of Baxter's most effective methods and it costs almost nothing.

A PRAYER

Lord God, You have sworn by Your own life that You take no pleasure in the death of the wicked, and I have not believed it about myself or about anyone else.

Forgive my silence. There are people I see every week whose souls I have never once mentioned to them, and I have called my cowardice discretion.

Give me the earnestness that pleads and the honesty that reasons, and keep me from every technique that works on people rather than serving them.

And if there is any part of me still postponing, let me settle it now. Amen.

The Nature of True Conversion

Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven.

MATTHEW 7:21

Having spent a book calling people to turn, Baxter spent another explaining what turning actually is — because he was convinced that a large proportion of the people in English parish churches believed themselves Christians on grounds that would not bear examination.

What conversion is not

He began by clearing away the false marks, and the list is uncomfortably current.

It is not being born into a Christian family, baptised, and taught the catechism. It is not moral respectability, which many unconverted people possess in greater measure than many converted ones. It is not orthodoxy of opinion — a man may hold every article correctly and be unchanged. It is not religious feeling, however strong; Baxter had watched people weep under preaching and return to their old lives within the week. And it is not the performance of religious duty, which can be maintained for a lifetime out of habit, fear or social necessity.

*Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name?
...And then will I profess unto them, I never knew you.*

MATTHEW 7:22–23

Baxter regarded that passage as the most sobering in the Bible for religious people, on the grounds that the persons addressed are not sceptics or scandalous sinners but active and apparently successful workers.

Three things that change

His positive account is unusually clear, and it is worth learning because it gives a believer something to examine himself by that is not a feeling.

Conversion, in Baxter's analysis, is a change in three related things.

A change of **ultimate end**. Every person is living for something — an aim which organises the rest. For the unconverted man, whatever his religion, that aim is finally himself: his comfort, his standing, his security, his pleasure. In conversion the end changes, and God takes the place the self occupied.

A change of **chief good**. Related but distinct. Every person has something he treats as his real happiness — the thing whose loss would ruin him. Baxter's test was to ask what a man would be unable to live without. Conversion is the transfer of that place to God.

Whom have I in heaven but thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside thee.

PSALM 73:25

A change of **governing master**. The convert has changed sides. He is no longer his own, and the will of Christ has become the authority to which disputes are referred.

To open their eyes, and to turn them from darkness to light, and from the power of Satan unto God.

ACTS 26:18

God's work and ours

Baxter held both sides firmly, and he was attacked from both directions for it.

Conversion is God's work. Nobody turns himself; the change described above is not within the reach of a will that is itself part of the problem.

A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh.

EZEKIEL 36:26

And conversion is genuinely the sinner's act. He turns; he repents; he believes. These are not things done to a passive object, and Scripture commands them of everyone who hears.

Baxter refused to resolve the tension by dropping either half, and he was impatient with those who did. To the man who said he could not turn, Baxter answered that nothing was preventing him but his own unwillingness. To the man who thought he could manage it whenever convenient, Baxter answered that he had never yet managed the smallest part of it and had better cry to God for help.

Gradual and definite

One further point, and it saves a good deal of unnecessary distress.

Baxter did not require that a believer be able to name the date of his conversion. He knew that many are brought up in godly homes and cannot identify a moment, and that the work is often gradual and only recognisable afterwards.

What he insisted on is that the change itself must be real and present, whatever its history. The question is not *when did it happen?* but *has*

it happened? — and that question is answered by examining what a person now lives for, treats as his happiness, and obeys.

Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

A caution before the applications, because this chapter can wound the wrong people.

Searching self-examination is medicine for the confident and poison for the fearful. Believers of tender conscience frequently fail every test they apply to themselves and conclude they are lost, while the genuinely unconverted sail through unbothered. If you are the sort of person who is already anxious about this, take the chapter gently, and read chapter fifteen before you go further.

The soil without depth

Baxter drew heavily on the parable of the sower, and particularly on the second soil, because it describes a person who looks converted and is not.

But he that received the seed into stony places, the same is he that heareth the word, and anon with joy receiveth it; yet hath he not root in himself, but dureth for a while: for when tribulation or persecution ariseth because of the word, by and by he is offended.

MATTHEW 13:20–21

Every detail matters. The response is immediate. It is joyful — more visibly enthusiastic, often, than that of the good soil. It is genuine as far as it goes; the man is not pretending. And it does not last.

The diagnosis is given in four words: *no root in himself*. Something happened at the surface which never reached the depth, and the plant was living on borrowed moisture.

Baxter's practical application was to warn against judging by early enthusiasm, either in others or in oneself. The most reliable evidence is time, and time cannot be hurried.

He also identified what typically exposes the difference: *tribulation or persecution*. Trouble is the test, because a religion adopted for what it supplies — comfort, belonging, a better life — has no reason to persist once it begins to cost.

The pastoral counsel that follows is patience. New believers should be received warmly and watched quietly, not promoted quickly. And a person who has fallen away is not to be written off; the parable describes what happened, not what must always happen. Roots can still go down.

1. Ask what you are actually living for — not what you would say, but what your decisions reveal.
2. Identify what you could not live without. That is your chief good, whatever your theology says.
3. Notice where you refer disputes. When your will and Christ's conflict, which one wins in practice?
4. Do not fret over the date. Ask whether the change is present, not when it began.
5. If this examination is crushing rather than clarifying, stop, and take it to a wise believer rather than continuing alone.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have called myself a Christian on grounds I have never examined, and I would rather know the truth now than discover it too late.

Show me what I am living for. Show me what I treat as my real happiness. Show me who wins when Your will and mine collide.

If I have never truly turned, turn me. I cannot do it, and I will not pretend I can; but I am asking, which is the one thing I can do.

And if I am Yours, quiet the fear that keeps accusing me, and let me rest in what You have done. Amen.

Faith and Justification

Therefore we conclude that a man is justified by faith without the deeds of the law.

ROMANS 3:28

This is the chapter in which Baxter must be read most carefully, because it deals with the point on which most of his own party judged him to have gone wrong.

It would be easy to leave it out. It is left out of most popular treatments of him. But a book that presented Baxter's pastoral genius while quietly omitting the doctrine that made him a byword for controversy would not be honest, and the reader would meet it eventually anyway.

What he was reacting against

Baxter's position was formed in the army, and that matters.

As a chaplain in the New Model Army in the mid-1640s he encountered opinions that horrified him — among them a species of Antinomianism which held that since the believer is justified by the imputed righteousness of Christ, his own conduct is in no way a condition of anything. Baxter saw men drawing the practical conclusion, and he never forgot it.

His *Aphorisms of Justification*, published in 1649, was written to close that door. It opened a controversy that occupied him, on and off, for the rest of his life.

What he taught

Set out as fairly as possible, his position ran roughly as follows.

Christ's death satisfied God's justice and procured a new covenant — a covenant of grace, whose terms are faith and repentance rather than perfect obedience. The sinner is justified not by keeping the old law, which he cannot, but by meeting the conditions of the new one, which by grace he can.

On this account, faith justifies as the appointed *condition* of the covenant rather than merely as the instrument that receives Christ's righteousness. And Baxter spoke of a personal, evangelical righteousness — consisting in sincere faith and repentance — alongside the righteousness of Christ, which he did not deny but understood differently from his critics. He also held a modified view of the atonement, that Christ died sufficiently for all and effectually for those who believe.

His motive throughout was pastoral. He was trying to secure the necessity of holiness against men who had made grace an excuse.

Why it was resisted

The objections came quickly, from John Owen among others, and they have been repeated ever since. They deserve to be stated plainly.

If faith justifies as a condition we perform, then it is difficult to see how it has not become a work — the very thing Paul excludes in the passages where the doctrine is defined.

But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness.

ROMANS 4:5

If our sincere faith and repentance constitute a personal righteousness that contributes to our standing, then the ground of acceptance has shifted, at least partly, from Christ to us — and the believer's assurance now depends on the adequacy of his own sincerity, which is precisely what the doctrine was meant to remove.

And be found in him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ, the righteousness which is of God by faith.

PHILIPPIANS 3:9

And the practical effect, critics argued, is the opposite of what Baxter intended. A believer who is uncertain whether his repentance has been sincere enough cannot rest, and a religion of anxious self-inspection is not more holy than one of settled faith. It is merely more miserable.

Baxter's later followers pressed his views further than he did, and the resulting controversy over what came to be called neonomianism divided English Nonconformity for generations.

Where this book stands

It would be evasive to set out both sides and decline to say anything.

The judgment of the great majority of Reformed theologians, then and since, is that Baxter erred here — that his concern to protect holiness was right, that his remedy compromised the freeness of justification, and that the New Testament secures holiness by a different route, namely union with Christ, which produces obedience as fruit rather than requiring it as a condition.

For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: not of works, lest any man should boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works.

EPHESIANS 2:8–10

Paul secures both in three verses, and the order is decisive. Works follow; they do not condition.

What is not in dispute

Having said that, three things should be added, and they matter.

Baxter was not preaching salvation by works, and it is a caricature to say so. He insisted on grace, on Christ's satisfaction, and on the impossibility of earning anything. The dispute was about the precise role of faith within a system all parties agreed was gracious.

His pastoral concern was legitimate and remains so. Antinomianism is a real disease, not a bogey; every generation produces Christians who treat forgiveness as permission.

And on everything else in this book — the ministry, heaven, catechising, family religion, the use of time — Baxter is a safe and superb guide. A man may be wrong at one point and reliable at fifty others, which is true of every teacher any of us has ever had.

The practical counsel is simple. On this question, follow Paul rather than Baxter. Rest your acceptance wholly on Christ's righteousness, received by faith which is itself God's gift, and let holiness grow from that security rather than be required as its price.

What both sides agreed

Before leaving this controversy it is worth stating what was not in dispute, because heated debates make participants sound further apart than they are.

Every party held that salvation is by grace. Nobody in the argument thought a sinner could earn acceptance with God, and nobody was proposing a religion of merit. Baxter would have rejected such a suggestion as forcefully as his critics.

Every party held that Christ's death is the sole ground of forgiveness. The dispute concerned how its benefits are conveyed and what part faith plays, not whether the cross was sufficient.

For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; who gave himself a ransom for all.

1 TIMOTHY 2:5–6

Every party held that faith is itself the gift of God, not a contribution the sinner produces from his own resources.

And every party held that genuine faith produces holiness. Baxter's critics were not Antinomians; they simply located the necessity of obedience elsewhere in the system than he did — as the fruit of union with Christ rather than as a condition of the covenant.

Follow peace with all men, and holiness, without which no man shall see the Lord.

The disagreement was real and it mattered, and this book has said where it thinks the weight of the argument lies. But it was a disagreement between men who agreed on a great deal, conducted with a sharpness that obscured the agreement — which is, as it happens, exactly what Baxter complained about when other people did it.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Settle where your acceptance rests. If it depends partly on the quality of your repentance, you will never have peace.
2. Notice which error you personally drift towards — treating grace as permission, or treating faith as a performance — and correct in the other direction.
3. Read Ephesians 2:8–10 and mark the order. Works follow; they do not condition.
4. Practise holding a teacher's error and his usefulness together. It is a skill every reader needs.
5. When assurance wobbles, look outward to Christ rather than inward to your sincerity.

A PRAYER

Father, I want to be holy, and I keep trying to secure it by making my acceptance depend on my performance — and then I have neither holiness nor peace.

Let my standing rest wholly on Christ. Not on the sincerity of my repentance, not on the strength of my faith, but on Him.

And out of that security, make me obedient. Let good works grow from what You have done rather than be demanded as the price of it.

Guard me from treating Your grace as permission. Guard me equally from treating Your gospel as a new law. Amen.

Take Heed to Yourselves

Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over the which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers.

ACTS 20:28

In 1656 Baxter published a book intended for the ministers of Worcestershire, written to accompany their agreement to take up systematic personal instruction in their parishes. It was an occasional piece for a local purpose. It has never been out of print since, and it is still set for theological students three and a half centuries later.

The Reformed Pastor takes its structure from Paul's charge at Miletus, and it follows the order of the text exactly. Take heed to yourselves comes first. Baxter would not let anyone reverse it.

The unconverted minister

He opened with a possibility that most books on ministry decline to raise: that a man may hold office, preach competently, be respected by his people, and be unconverted.

Baxter thought this was neither rare nor hypothetical. A man may enter the ministry as a career, learn its vocabulary fluently, and never once have dealt with God on his own account. He may spend his life urging others to a place he has not been.

Thou therefore which teachest another, teachest thou not thyself?

ROMANS 2:21

But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.

1 CORINTHIANS 9:27

That verse is Paul's, about Paul. Baxter's point was that if the apostle considered the danger worth naming, no minister since has grounds for complacency.

Preaching against sins you live in

His second warning is subtler and touches everyone who teaches.

It is entirely possible, Baxter observed, to preach against a sin with real force while practising it. The pulpit provides a curious immunity: a man denouncing covetousness is not, at that moment, thinking of himself, and the very act of condemning the fault can produce a comfortable sense of being on the right side of it.

He was specific about the ministerial versions. **Pride** he named as the chief — pride in gifts, in learning, in reputation, in the size of a congregation, in being thought humble. **Laziness**, disguised as study. **Worldliness**, disguised as prudence about money. And **contentiousness**, disguised as zeal for truth.

That last one he applied to himself without hesitation, and anyone who has read his controversial writings will agree that the diagnosis was accurate.

And why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye?

MATTHEW 7:3

The example

Baxter's third emphasis is that a minister teaches chiefly by what he is.

The congregation is watching, and it learns more from how a man treats his family, handles money, responds to criticism and speaks of his opponents than from anything he says in a sermon. A discrepancy between the two is noticed immediately, and it does more damage than any amount of poor preaching.

Be thou an example of the believers, in word, in conversation, in charity, in spirit, in faith, in purity.

1 TIMOTHY 4:12

He drew the practical conclusion that a minister's private devotion is not a personal matter. A man who neglects his own soul is not merely damaging himself; he is depriving his people, because he can only give what he has.

Take heed unto thyself, and unto the doctrine; continue in them: for in doing this thou shalt both save thyself, and them that hear thee.

1 TIMOTHY 4:16

A necessary caution

Now a warning about the book itself, because it must be said.

The Reformed Pastor is one of the most searching books in the English language and one of the most crushing. Baxter's standard is extraordinarily high, his tone is relentless, and he shows very little interest in comforting the reader. Ministers who are already conscientious — which is to say, exactly the ministers who read it — have been driven by it into despair and, in some cases, out of the ministry altogether.

That was not his intention, and it is a misuse of the book. Baxter was writing to rouse men who had grown complacent, not to finish off men who were already at the end of themselves.

The safeguard is to read it with the gospel in the other hand. Every failure it exposes is a failure Christ has already borne. A minister who

reads it and is convicted should repent and change one thing; a minister who reads it and despairs has forgotten that his acceptance was never based on his performance in the first place.

There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus.

ROMANS 8:1

Not only for ministers

One further note, because most readers of this book are not pastors.

Everything in this chapter applies, at a smaller scale, to anyone who teaches anyone — a parent, a Sunday school teacher, an elder, a small group leader, an older believer who has taken a younger one under their wing.

The order is the same. Take heed to yourself first. What you are will reach the people in your care more surely than what you say, and the discrepancy between the two, if there is one, will be noticed long before you notice it.

Baxter's most useful question for anyone who teaches is short and can be asked tonight.

Is there anything you regularly urge on others that you are not currently practising yourself?

Two particular pressures

Baxter singled out two areas where ministers most often fail, and both are places where the failure is visible to everyone except the man himself.

The first is his household. Paul makes the connection explicit and gives the reason.

One that ruleth well his own house, having his children in subjection with all gravity; (for if a man know not how to rule his own house, how shall he take care of the church of God?)

1 TIMOTHY 3:4–5

Baxter observed that a man may give his best hours to the parish and arrive home with nothing left, so that the people who most need him receive the worst of him. He regarded this as a straightforward failure of duty rather than a regrettable side effect of zeal, and he warned that a congregation is not deceived by it for long.

The second is money. Not, usually, dramatic dishonesty — but the slow accommodation by which a man's standard of living, ambitions and choice of associates come to be shaped by financial interest without his ever having made a decision about it.

Not greedy of filthy lucre, but of a ready mind; neither as being lords over God's heritage, but being ensamples to the flock.

Baxter's own practice was severe: he lived plainly, gave away a large part of a modest income, and refused preferment when it was offered. He did not require others to match him, and he did require that the question be faced.

His test was to ask whether any decision in a man's ministry over the last year had been influenced by what it would cost him. The answer, honestly given, is usually informative.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name one thing you regularly urge on others and are not doing. Begin doing it this week.
2. Examine yourself for the four ministerial sins — pride, laziness, worldliness, contentiousness — and identify which is yours.
3. Ask whether your own devotional life exists independently of your preparation to teach. If not, that is the finding.
4. If this chapter crushes you rather than convicting you, stop and read Romans 8:1. Change one thing; do not despair.
5. If you have never settled the question of your own conversion, settle it before you teach anyone else anything.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have urged on others what I do not practise, and I have denounced sins from a position that felt safe while I was denouncing them.

Search me. Show me the pride I have dressed up as conviction, the laziness I have called study, the love of money I have called prudence, the quarrelsomeness I have called zeal.

Keep my own soul, so that I have something to give. Let me take heed to myself before I take heed to anyone else.

And when I see how far short I fall, do not let me despair. My standing was never built on my performance. Amen.

Take Heed to All the Flock

*Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight thereof,
not by constraint, but willingly.*

1 PETER 5:2

The second half of Paul's charge governs the second half of Baxter's book, and he fastened on one word in it: *all*.

Every single one

Take heed to *all* the flock. Not the responsive ones, not the ones who attend regularly, not the ones whose conversation is agreeable or whose support is useful. All of them.

Baxter took this to mean that a minister is responsible for every individual in his charge by name, and that he cannot discharge that responsibility from a pulpit alone. Preaching addresses a congregation; oversight requires knowing people.

He was blunt about the arithmetic. If a parish is too large for its minister to know its members individually, then either he must obtain help or the parish must be divided — but he may not simply preach at a crowd and call it oversight, because that is not what the word means.

*And I will set up shepherds over them which shall feed them: and they shall fear
no more, nor be dismayed, neither shall they be lacking.*

JEREMIAH 23:4

The weight of it

Baxter's motivation was an accountability he could not get out of his mind.

*Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch
for your souls, as they that must give account.*

HEBREWS 13:17

*When I say unto the wicked, Thou shalt surely die; and thou givest him not warning
...his blood will I require at thine hand.*

EZEKIEL 3:18

The watchman passage in Ezekiel shaped his whole ministry. It is a terrifying text, and Baxter did not soften it. The watchman who fails to warn is held responsible for what follows; the watchman who warns and is ignored is clear.

He drew from it a rule that governed his practice: it is not enough to have preached the truth in general to a congregation. A minister

must be able to say that he has told each person, personally, what their situation is.

What oversight involves

Baxter set out what he thought the work actually required, and it is a heavy list.

Knowing the people — their circumstances, their families, their trades, their temptations, and the state of their souls so far as it can be known. Instructing them individually, which is the subject of the next chapter. Attending particularly to the young, to new converts, and to those under conviction. Visiting the sick and the dying, which he regarded as the point at which a minister earns whatever standing he has. Comforting the distressed, and distinguishing between those who need comfort and those who need warning — which he thought the hardest skill in pastoral work and the one most often got backwards.

Now we exhort you, brethren, warn them that are unruly, comfort the feeble-minded, support the weak, be patient toward all men.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:14

Four categories, four different treatments, in a single verse. Baxter's point is that a minister who has only one manner will damage three-quarters of his congregation.

Discipline, and its limits

He also pressed the exercise of church discipline, which had largely lapsed in the parishes of his day, and this was among the most contested parts of his programme.

His concern was not punitive. He held that admitting to the Lord's Table people who gave no evidence of faith or repentance was cruel to them — confirming them in a false assurance — as well as damaging to the church's witness.

It is worth adding, since Baxter's era used discipline in ways later generations have rightly questioned, that the New Testament's aim throughout is restoration.

Brethren, if a man be overtaken in a fault, ye which are spiritual, restore such an one in the spirit of meekness; considering thyself, lest thou also be tempted.

GALATIANS 6:1

Considering thyself. Discipline exercised by people who have forgotten that clause becomes something else very quickly.

The people's part

One final observation, since congregations read books like this too.

Baxter assumed a reciprocal obligation. If the minister is bound

to know his people, the people are bound to be knowable — to make themselves available, to answer honestly, to receive instruction, and to support the work so that the man is not so distracted by earning a living that he cannot do it.

And we beseech you, brethren, to know them which labour among you ...and to esteem them very highly in love for their work's sake.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:12–13

A congregation that wants the kind of ministry Baxter describes must be willing to be pastored, which is a more demanding thing than most people expect.

The question this chapter puts to a church leader is simple and quantifiable.

Could you write down the names of the people in your care, and say something true about the spiritual condition of each?

Going after the one

There is a duty in the oversight of a congregation which Baxter thought almost universally neglected, and it is the pursuit of those who have drifted away.

Ye have not strengthened the diseased, neither have ye healed that which was sick, neither have ye bound up that which was broken, neither have ye brought again that which was driven away, neither have ye sought that which was lost.

EZEKIEL 34:4

That is God's indictment of the shepherds of Israel, and every clause describes an omission rather than an act of cruelty. They did not drive the sheep away; they simply did not go after them.

The Lord's own picture is more vivid still. A man with a hundred sheep loses one and leaves the ninety-nine to look for it, and when he finds it he carries it home rejoicing.

And when he hath found it, he layeth it on his shoulders, rejoicing.

LUKE 15:5

Baxter's practical observation was that congregations lose people quietly. Nobody announces a departure. Attendance thins, then stops, and after a few weeks the absence has become normal and nobody can quite remember when it began. Six months later it is awkward to make contact, and so nobody does.

His counsel was to move early and without accusation. Go, or send someone. Ask how they are rather than why they have not been. Assume difficulty rather than rebellion, because it usually is — illness, shame, a quarrel, a bereavement, a period of doubt they did not know how to mention.

The one who has drifted rarely needs to be told they have drifted. They generally need to discover that somebody noticed.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. If you lead, write out the names of those in your charge. Note beside each what you actually know of their spiritual state. The gaps are the work.
2. Identify the person in your congregation you know least and like least. Begin there.
3. Learn the four categories of 1 Thessalonians 5:14 and check whether you treat everyone the same way.
4. If you are a church member, make yourself knowable. Answer honestly when asked, and do not require your leaders to guess.
5. Visit someone who is sick or dying this month. It is where pastoral credibility is earned.

A PRAYER

Lord, You have made me responsible for people, and I have preached at them instead of knowing them.

Forgive me for attending to the responsive and neglecting the difficult. Show me the ones I have quietly written off.

Give me discernment to warn the unruly and comfort the fainthearted, and not to confuse the two.

And keep the weight of it on me — that I watch for souls as one who must give account — without letting that weight crush me. Amen.

The Work of Catechising

And how I kept back nothing that was profitable unto you, but have shewed you, and have taught you publickly, and from house to house.

ACTS 20:20

Here is the practice that made Kidderminster famous, and it is the most transferable thing Baxter ever did.

He and his assistant set aside two full days every week for personal instruction. Families came to his house by appointment, one household at a time. He went through the essentials of the Christian faith with them, asked what they understood, corrected what they had wrong, and dealt with each person about the state of their own soul. They worked through around fourteen families a week and covered the whole parish — some eight hundred families — in a year.

Then they began again.

Why preaching was not enough

Baxter loved preaching and was good at it. His argument was not against it but about its limits.

From a pulpit you cannot tell what has been understood. People sit through sermons for decades, nodding, and turn out on examination to hold a confused folk-religion assembled from fragments. Baxter reported the experience of discovering that respectable parishioners of long standing could not say who Christ was or what He had done, having heard him preach both weekly for years.

Personal instruction solves this because it is two-way. The person has to answer. Their actual understanding becomes visible, and you can address what is genuinely there rather than what you assumed.

Whom we preach, warning every man, and teaching every man in all wisdom; that we may present every man perfect in Christ Jesus.

COLOSSIANS 1:28

Baxter noticed that Paul says *every man* three times in one verse, and concluded that the apostolic method was individual as well as public.

What he found

His reported results were startling and he was careful about them.

He said that he learned more about his people in one hour of personal conversation than in years of preaching to them, and that more

apparent conversions followed this work than followed his public ministry — though he added, honestly, that the preaching had prepared much of what the conversation harvested.

He also found the work humbling. Ministers who take it up generally discover that their preaching has been aimed at a congregation that does not exist: better informed, more attentive and less confused than the actual people in the pews.

The practicalities

Baxter was characteristically detailed about the method, and the details are what make it usable.

Give them something first. He supplied each family with a printed catechism ahead of the visit, so they knew what would be discussed and could prepare. He bought these and distributed them himself.

Take them one household at a time. Privacy matters. People will not admit ignorance in front of neighbours, and will not discuss their souls in a crowd.

Begin with knowledge, and move to the conscience. Establish what they understand, then apply it personally — what does this mean for you, and where are you in relation to it?

Be gentle with the ignorant. Baxter insisted on this. Shaming a person for not knowing something guarantees they will never tell you the truth again.

Keep records, so that the next round can build on the last.

And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way.

DEUTERONOMY 6:7

The objections he answered

He anticipated the excuses, and they are still the ones we use.

There is no time. Baxter's reply was that there is time for whatever we consider essential, and that a man who cannot find two days a week for the souls in his charge should examine what the other days are going to.

The people will not come. At Kidderminster nearly all of them did, once it was explained and expected. He acknowledged that in other places they might not, and answered that a minister is responsible for offering, not for the response.

It is not my gift. Baxter regarded this as the least respectable of the objections. The work does not require unusual gifts. It requires knowing the faith, caring about people, and being willing to spend the hours.

Most readers of this book are not clergy, and the practice adapts.

Any believer can do this with one other person: a child, a new convert, a friend who is curious, someone in the congregation younger than themselves. Take a short catechism or a book of the Bible, meet regularly, ask what they understand rather than telling them what they should, and press it home gently.

It is the least glamorous method in Christian history, and it has a better record than most of the others.

What to teach

Baxter was specific about the content of personal instruction, and his structure is worth having because it prevents the whole exercise from wandering.

He worked from the traditional four heads, which Protestants and Catholics alike had used for generations and which cover the ground with remarkable economy.

The **Creed** — what a Christian believes. Who God is, what He has done in creation and redemption, who Christ is, what the Spirit does, what the church is, and what is coming.

The **Ten Commandments** — how a Christian lives. Baxter used these not as a ladder to be climbed but as a mirror, to show a person his need, and then as a map, to show him the shape of obedience.

The **Lord's Prayer** — what a Christian asks for. He found this the most useful of the four for exposing the state of a heart, since what a person wants reveals more than what he professes.

And the **sacraments** — baptism and the Lord's Supper, what they mean and what is required of those who come.

Hold fast the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me, in faith and love which is in Christ Jesus.

2 TIMOTHY 1:13

The great advantage of a fixed structure is that it prevents a teacher from following his own enthusiasms. Left to ourselves we teach what interests us, and whole areas go untouched for years. A settled framework guarantees that everyone receives the whole of it.

Baxter added one instruction that governs the rest: do not merely establish that a person can repeat the words. Ask what each clause means, and what difference it makes to them. A parishioner who could recite the Creed perfectly and had no idea what any of it signified was, in his experience, the commonest discovery of all.

1. Choose one person and begin meeting with them regularly to go through the Christian faith. Start this month.
2. Ask questions rather than delivering content. You cannot address what you have not discovered.
3. Give them something to prepare from — a catechism, a book, a passage — so the meeting has a spine.
4. Be gentle with ignorance. Shame ends honesty permanently.
5. If you lead a church, audit how much of your ministry is one-directional. Then change one thing about your diary.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have spoken a great deal and discovered very little about what the people around me actually believe.

Give me the patience for the slow work — one person at a time, asking rather than telling, learning what is really there before I try to correct it.

Make me gentle with those who know little. Let no one be ashamed to admit their ignorance to me.

And give me the diligence to keep at it when it is unremarkable and nobody is watching. Amen.

Family Religion

But as for me and my house, we will serve the Lord.

JOSHUA 24:15

Baxter held a conviction that runs through his entire practical theology and that he stated as bluntly as he could: that the reformation of the church depends on the reformation of families, and that a nation of godly households would need very little else.

He was not being rhetorical. In *A Christian Directory* he devoted an entire part to the ordering of households, and he wrote a separate volume for poor families who could afford nothing longer.

The household as the first church

His argument was that God has arranged the world so that most religious formation happens at home, whatever the church does.

A person spends an hour or two a week under preaching and the rest of his life in a household. If the two contradict each other, the household wins. Children raised in a home where religion is professed on Sunday and absent from Monday to Saturday learn, accurately, that it is a social observance.

For I know him, that he will command his children and his household after him, and they shall keep the way of the Lord.

GENESIS 18:19

Baxter noticed that God's commendation of Abraham is not about his faith in the abstract but about what he would do with his household. Similarly, the qualification for an elder turns on the same point.

One that ruleth well his own house, having his children in subjection with all gravity; (for if a man know not how to rule his own house, how shall he take care of the church of God?)

1 TIMOTHY 3:4–5

The head of the house as its minister

From this Baxter drew a conclusion that many Christians still find surprising: the head of a household has a genuinely pastoral office within it.

He is to teach the faith to those in his care, pray with them, examine what they understand, correct them, and set the example. Baxter regarded this not as an optional enthusiasm for the unusually devout but as a plain duty attached to the position.

And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord.

EPHESIANS 6:4

Note both halves. The instruction is commanded; so is the manner of it. Baxter was firm that harsh, hectoring family religion produces the opposite of what it intends, and he warned parents that a child driven to resent the faith may carry that resentment for life.

What it actually looked like

He was practical about the shape of it, and the shape is simple enough to adopt this week.

A fixed time, kept daily, so that it does not depend on anyone remembering or feeling like it. Baxter favoured morning and evening; one is better than none.

Everyone present — children, servants, lodgers. The household means the household.

Reading, a short passage, read aloud.

Instruction, brief and pitched at the youngest person in the room rather than the oldest. Baxter was emphatic on this. A father who conducts family worship at the level of his own understanding is talking to himself.

Prayer, short, specific and audible — covering the day's actual business rather than generalities.

Singing, where the household can manage it.

Above all, brief. Baxter warned that long family devotions produce children who dread the hour, and that a short exercise faithfully kept accomplishes far more than a long one abandoned within a fortnight.

That the generation to come might know them, even the children which should be born; who should arise and declare them to their children.

PSALM 78:6

Where the household is divided

A qualification Baxter's own century needed less than ours does.

Many readers are not in a position to institute family worship. A believing wife with an unbelieving husband, a young person in a hostile home, a single person, a worker in someone else's household — the pattern above assumes an authority they do not have.

The New Testament addresses exactly this situation, and its counsel is not to force the issue.

Likewise, ye wives, be in subjection to your own husbands; that, if any obey not the word, they also may without the word be won by the conversation of the wives.

1 PETER 3:1

Without the word — won by conduct rather than argument. A believer in a divided household may pray privately, live consistently, take whatever opportunity is given, and leave the rest to God without concluding that they have failed.

The long view

One further encouragement, since family religion is the least immediately rewarding thing most Christians do.

It is almost entirely invisible. Nobody applauds it. Its results, if they come, appear twenty years later in the character of people who will not remember where they got it. A parent conducting a short reading and prayer with distracted children on a wet Tuesday evening has no evidence that anything is happening, and usually feels faintly ridiculous.

Baxter's answer was that God has appointed means, and that we are responsible for the means rather than the outcome.

And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not.

GALATIANS 6:9

If your household has no regular time of worship, the useful thing to take from this chapter is not a conviction but an appointment. Choose the time before you put the book down.

The whole household

A word about the word *household*, because it meant something broader in Baxter's century than it does in ours, and the breadth is worth recovering.

The households he addressed included servants, apprentices, journeymen and lodgers — people who lived under the roof and worked in the business without being related to anyone. Baxter's instructions to heads of households cover all of them without distinction. The apprentice was to be taught and prayed for exactly as the son was.

A devout man, and one that feared God with all his house, which gave much alms to the people, and prayed to God alway.

ACTS 10:2

Cornelius is commended for the state of his whole house, and when Peter arrives he finds a room full of relatives and close friends assembled to hear.

The modern application is not obvious but it is real. Few readers employ live-in apprentices. Most have some equivalent — a lodger, a student, an elderly relative, a neighbour's child who is always in the kitchen, a colleague who comes for meals, an employee whose life you know something about.

Baxter's principle was that responsibility follows proximity. The people whose lives regularly intersect with yours are, to some degree, your charge, whether or not the arrangement is formal.

The practical form of this is hospitality, and Scripture commands it more often than we generally notice.

Use hospitality one to another without grudging.

1 PETER 4:9

A household where the faith is quietly practised, and to which people are regularly invited, does an evangelistic work that no programme can duplicate — because what visitors observe over a dinner table cannot be staged.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Fix a daily time for household worship and start tomorrow. Ten minutes is enough.
2. Pitch it at the youngest person present, not the oldest.
3. Keep it short. A brief exercise sustained for years beats a long one abandoned in a month.
4. Check your manner. Are you provoking the people you are trying to instruct?
5. If you cannot lead in your household, do what is open to you — private prayer and consistent conduct — and do not condemn yourself for what is not in your power.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have expected the church to do what You gave to my household, and I have been too busy or too self-conscious to begin.

Give me the resolve to fix a time and keep it, and the humility to pitch it where the youngest can follow.

Guard my manner. Let me never make the faith something my family is glad to escape.

And where I see nothing for years, keep me from weariness. The seed is Yours and so is the harvest. Amen.

The Life of Faith

Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.

HEBREWS 11:1

Baxter preached a sermon before the king in 1660 on the life of faith, and afterwards expanded it into one of his most useful books. Its thesis is a diagnosis of the ordinary Christian's real problem, and it is not the one we usually name.

The problem is not doubt

We assume that a believer's difficulty is intellectual — that he is troubled by objections and needs his questions answered.

Baxter thought this was true of very few. The great majority of Christians, he argued, do not doubt the doctrines at all. They affirm them sincerely, would defend them if challenged, and are entirely unaffected by them.

The problem is not disbelief but unreality. We hold that God is present, that heaven is coming, that souls are eternal — and we live as though the visible world were the only solid one, because it is the one that presses on our senses every waking moment.

While we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen: for the things which are seen are temporal; but the things which are not seen are eternal.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:18

Baxter's illustration was the difference between a man who knows there is a fire in the next street and a man who can see it. Both believe the same fact. Only one is moving.

Faith as a second sight

His definition of faith follows from this. Faith is the faculty by which the unseen world becomes as real to us as the seen one — not more certain, since God's word is more certain than our eyes, but as *present*.

The chapter he worked from is Hebrews 11, and he pointed out what is said of Moses.

By faith he forsook Egypt, not fearing the wrath of the king: for he endured, as seeing him who is invisible.

HEBREWS 11:27

As seeing him who is invisible. That is the whole matter in a phrase. Moses acted against every visible consideration because something invisible was more real to him.

And of the patriarchs:

These all died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them afar off, and were persuaded of them, and embraced them.

HEBREWS 11:13

Baxter drew out the sequence: they saw, they were persuaded, they embraced. Sight first — the sight faith gives — and conduct followed from it.

Where it bites

The practical value of this analysis is that it redirects our efforts.

If our problem were doubt, the remedy would be argument. Since our problem is unreality, the remedy is attention — and this is exactly why Baxter placed such weight on meditation. The unseen becomes real to the person who deliberately attends to it, and stays theoretical for everyone else.

He applied it in several directions.

To money. A man who genuinely saw the two worlds would find the calculations easy. The difficulty is not that we think the heavenly treasure inferior; it is that we cannot see it, and the visible pound is here in the hand.

To suffering. Paul's arithmetic in 2 Corinthians 4 — a light affliction, working an eternal weight of glory — is not consolation offered against the evidence. It is a sober comparison, available to anyone who can see both terms.

To death. Baxter, who expected his own for fifty years, held that the fear of dying is largely a failure of sight. What is feared is a vacancy, because the other side is not being looked at.

Living by faith daily

He was practical about how faith is exercised, and it comes down to a habit of recall.

The believer, several times a day, deliberately calls to mind what is actually the case: that God is present in this room; that the person in front of him will exist for ever; that this hour is being recorded; that Christ is at the right hand of God and is not indifferent to what is happening here.

None of that is new information. It is the deliberate application of information already held, and Baxter thought the whole difference between a vigorous Christian and a dull one lies in whether it is done.

I have set the Lord always before me: because he is at my right hand, I shall not be moved.

PSALM 16:8

There is a test in this that anyone can apply honestly.

Consider something you say you believe — that God sees you, or that you will give account, or that heaven is real. Then look at your last week and ask what you would have done differently if you had not believed it.

If the answer is nothing, the belief is not yet operative, and the remedy is not more information.

Faith and the promises

If faith is living by the unseen, the question is what it holds on to — and Baxter's answer was: particular promises, in particular words.

He was impatient with a faith that consisted of general good feeling about God's character. Feelings about God fluctuate; a sentence He has spoken does not.

Whereby are given unto us exceeding great and precious promises: that by these ye might be partakers of the divine nature.

2 PETER 1:4

His counsel was to gather promises deliberately — to know where they are, to write them down, to have particular ones for particular troubles, so that when the trouble arrives the search does not have to begin then.

Abraham is the model, and Paul is careful about the mechanism.

He staggered not at the promise of God through unbelief; but was strong in faith, giving glory to God; and being fully persuaded that, what he had promised, he was able also to perform.

ROMANS 4:20–21

Two things anchor him: a promise that was made, and a God who is able. Nothing in the account depends on Abraham's feelings, which by the evidence of Genesis were frequently poor.

Baxter added a distinction that saves a good deal of confusion. Some promises are absolute and belong to every believer without condition — forgiveness, the Spirit's indwelling, final preservation. Others are attached to conditions, and some concern outcomes God has not committed Himself to in any particular case. Claiming the second sort as though they were the first produces disappointment and, eventually, the conclusion that God does not keep His word.

Know which is which. Then hold the first without any hesitation at all.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Take one doctrine you affirm and ask what you would have done differently last week had you not believed it. Sit with the answer.
2. Practise deliberate recall three times tomorrow: God is present here; this person is eternal; this hour is being recorded.
3. Where a decision about money is difficult, name both terms of the comparison honestly. The difficulty is usually one of sight, not of principle.
4. When afraid, ask whether you are looking at the trouble and not at God. Then look.
5. Stop treating your problem as intellectual if it is not. Give the time you would have spent on arguments to attention instead.

A PRAYER

Lord, I believe a great many things that have made no difference to me, and I have called that faith.

My trouble is not that I doubt You. It is that You are not real to me in the way this room is real, and so I live by what I can see.

Give me the sight that faith gives. Let me endure as seeing Him who is invisible.

Bring the unseen close today — Your presence, the worth of the people around me, the account I shall give — and let it change what I actually do. Amen.

Self-Examination

Examine yourselves, whether ye be in the faith; prove your own selves.

2 CORINTHIANS 13:5

Baxter was a physician of souls in an almost literal sense — he studied medicine, catalogued his own ailments with clinical precision, and applied the same method to the inner life. Diagnosis before treatment.

He held that most Christians never examine themselves at all, that a minority examine themselves destructively, and that a small number do it well. The distinction between the last two is the burden of this chapter.

Why it is commanded

Scripture requires it, and Baxter began there.

Let us search and try our ways, and turn again to the Lord.

LAMENTATIONS 3:40

But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:28

The reason it is necessary is the one Scripture also gives: we cannot be trusted to know ourselves without effort.

The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked: who can know it?

JEREMIAH 17:9

Baxter took the second clause seriously. The heart is not merely corrupt; it is corrupt in a way that conceals itself from its owner. Which means that a comfortable general impression of oneself is worth very little, and that the matter requires deliberate work.

The method

He recommended a set practice, and it is unglamorous.

A fixed time, preferably daily, at the end of the day, before sleep. He thought weekly review too infrequent, since by then most of the material has been forgotten.

Specific questions, rather than a general trawl. Baxter supplied lists; the value is in their concreteness. How did I use this day? Where did I sin, and in what did it begin? What did I neglect that I ought to have done? What was I angry about, and what does that reveal? How

did I treat the people in my house? Where was I proud? Did I speak of anyone in a way I would not repeat to their face?

Commune with your own heart upon your bed, and be still.

PSALM 4:4

Confession as you go, rather than accumulating a list. The point of the exercise is not to compile evidence but to deal with what is found.

And a resolution, small and specific, for tomorrow.

The invitation that makes it safe

Here is the element that distinguishes healthy self-examination from morbid introspection, and Baxter knew it well.

Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts: and see if there be any wicked way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting.

PSALM 139:23–24

Notice that David does not examine himself alone. He asks God to do it.

This changes everything about the exercise. A person searching his own heart by himself is using a faculty that is part of the problem, and he will either find too little or too much depending on his temperament. A person inviting God to search him is in company, and the searching is conducted by Someone who already knows the worst and has not withdrawn.

Note also where the psalm ends: *lead me in the way everlasting*. The purpose is forward movement, not an inventory.

When it goes wrong

Baxter was unusually alert to the failure mode, and this is one of the places where his pastoral wisdom is at its best.

Self-examination is medicine for the presumptuous and poison for the fearful. The people who most need it are those who never do it; the people who do it most are frequently those who should do it less. A tender conscience, turned relentlessly inward, produces not holiness but paralysis — and it can slide into the condition Baxter called melancholy, which is the subject of chapter fifteen.

His safeguards are worth stating.

Examine yourself at set times, and then stop. Do not carry the inquest through the day.

Examine your conduct rather than your feelings. Feelings vary with health, weather and sleep, and prove very little.

End by looking outward. The exercise should finish at Christ, not at yourself, because that is where the remedy is.

Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith.

And if you cannot do it without despair, do not do it alone. Take it to a wise believer who knows you.

The most practical thing here is the smallest. Tonight, before sleep, ask four questions about today, deal with what surfaces, and stop.

Ten minutes, honestly spent, will show you more than a year of vague unease.

Watching the heart

One further emphasis, because Baxter thought it the point at which most self-examination is aimed too late.

Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.

PROVERBS 4:23

The proverb locates the work upstream. By the time a sin has reached speech or action it has already been forming for some while, and examining only the outcome is like inspecting a river at its mouth and wondering where the silt came from.

Baxter's counsel was to attend to beginnings. Not the angry word, but the resentment that had been maturing for a fortnight. Not the dishonest act, but the small compromise months earlier that made it thinkable. Not the affair, but the first conversation that was enjoyed more than it should have been.

He observed that we generally know. Something registers at the time — a slight unease, a reluctance to mention it to anyone — and is overruled. That overruling, repeated, is how a conscience is trained into silence.

Take us the foxes, the little foxes, that spoil the vines.

SONG OF SOLOMON 2:15

The practical form is to ask, in the nightly review, not only what was done but where it began. What was I thinking about while I waited? What did I turn over with pleasure? What did I decide not to mention?

Baxter added an encouragement that keeps this from becoming oppressive. Watching the heart is not the same as distrusting every impulse. A believer whose heart has been renewed will find many of its motions good, and God is at work there. The discipline is one of attention rather than suspicion — noticing what is rising, in order to feed what is of God and starve what is not.

Coming to the Table

The New Testament attaches self-examination to one occasion in particular, and Baxter gave it corresponding weight.

But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:28

The context is a congregation whose behaviour at the Lord's Supper had become a scandal — divisions, the rich eating while the poor went without — and Paul's instruction is that each person should look at himself before he comes.

Baxter's parishes observed a period of preparation before communion, which is where much of his personal instruction took place. The practice has largely lapsed, and something has been lost with it.

But the examination Paul commands must be read carefully, because it is frequently turned into the opposite of its purpose. He does not tell the Corinthians to stay away until they are worthy; nobody would ever come. He tells them to examine themselves *and so* to eat. The examination is the road to the Table, not a barrier before it.

This is a faithful saying ...that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners; of whom I am chief.

1 TIMOTHY 1:15

The questions to ask are therefore specific and limited. Am I trusting Christ? Is there any sin I am holding on to and intending to keep? Is there anyone here I am unreconciled with?

That third question is the one Paul's context presses hardest and the one we most often skip. A congregation that examined itself about its relationships before communion, rather than only about its private sins, would look rather different within a year.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Set a nightly time — ten minutes — and use specific questions rather than a general survey.
2. Ask God to do the searching rather than doing it alone. It is both safer and more accurate.
3. Confess as you go and finish with one small resolution for tomorrow.
4. Examine conduct rather than feelings. Feelings track your sleep more closely than your soul.
5. End by looking at Christ. If the exercise leaves you looking at yourself, you have stopped one step early.

A PRAYER

Lord, I know myself less well than I suppose, and my heart hides its worst from me. I will not attempt this alone. Search me, O God, and know my heart. Show me what I did today, what I neglected, what I said, and what it came from.

Give me the honesty to see it and the faith to bring it straight to You rather than turning it over in the dark.

And lead me in the way everlasting — forward, not merely inward. Amen.

The Crucifying of the World

But God forbid that I should glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by whom the world is crucified unto me, and I unto the world.

GALATIANS 6:14

In 1658 Baxter published a treatise with a title that states its whole argument: *The Crucifying of the World by the Cross of Christ*. It is his fullest treatment of worldliness, and he regarded worldliness as the commonest and most respectable way of losing one's soul.

A sin that is never named

His starting observation is that this is the one great sin about which the church is habitually silent.

Congregations denounce drunkenness, dishonesty and immorality. Almost nobody preaches against the love of money, and almost nobody confesses it. Baxter thought this was not because the sin is rare but because it is universal among the respectable, and because it wears the clothes of prudence, providing for one's family, and good stewardship.

Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world. If any man love the world, the love of the Father is not in him.

1 JOHN 2:15

He was careful to define the term, because it is easy to caricature. Worldliness is not the possession of things, nor the enjoyment of them, nor the ordinary diligence by which a person feeds a household. God gives good things to be enjoyed with thanksgiving.

Worldliness is the setting of the heart on them. It is treating this life's goods as our portion rather than our provision — and Baxter's test was to ask not what a man owns but what he could not bear to lose.

For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

MATTHEW 6:21

Why persuasion fails

Here is the argument that makes his treatment distinctive, and it is the reason for the title.

Everyone already agrees that the world is passing. Preach a sermon on the vanity of riches and the congregation will nod; not one of them disputes it. And nothing changes, because the heart is not moved by information it already possesses.

The world's grip, Baxter argued, is not broken by being told it is worthless. It is broken by a rival attachment, and the only thing strong enough is the cross.

By whom the world is crucified unto me, and I unto the world.

GALATIANS 6:14

Paul's phrase runs both ways, and Baxter dwelt on the symmetry. The world is crucified to me: seen from the foot of the cross, its offers lose their appeal. I am crucified to the world: it no longer has anything to hold, because the person it used to bargain with has died.

The practical method that follows is not resolution but contemplation. A man who wants to be free of the love of money will get further by an hour at Calvary than by an hour of resolving to be less greedy.

Prosperity is the harder test

Baxter made an observation that is uncomfortable in wealthy societies.

Scripture treats poverty as a danger and prosperity as a greater one. The reason is that adversity drives people to God while comfort quietly persuades them they do not need Him — and does it so gradually that nobody notices the transition.

But they that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition.

1 TIMOTHY 6:9

He noted that Paul does not say the rich but *they that will be rich* — those who have set their intention that way. The condition is one of ambition rather than balance.

Baxter's own practice matched his preaching. He lived simply, gave away a large part of a modest income, refused a bishopric, and bought books to distribute at his own expense in quantities he could not really afford.

What to do with what you have

He was not an ascetic, and his counsel is constructive rather than merely prohibitive.

Charge them that are rich in this world, that they be not highminded, nor trust in uncertain riches, but in the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy; that they do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate.

1 TIMOTHY 6:17–18

Note that Paul commands enjoyment in the same breath as generosity. God gives things *richly to enjoy*, and a sour refusal of good gifts is not holiness.

Baxter's directions were practical. Hold possessions as a steward rather than an owner. Give proportionally and regularly rather than occasionally and emotionally. Decide in advance what is enough, since a level that is never defined is never reached. And watch the direction of travel: whether your standard of living rises automatically with every increase in income, which is the surest evidence that the heart is set where the treasure is.

The most useful question this chapter puts is Baxter's own, and it takes about ten seconds to answer.

Not *how much do you own?* — but *what could you not bear to lose?*

The subtler worldliness

Money is the form of worldliness that gets named, and Baxter thought it was not the most dangerous one for religious people.

The subtler form is the love of reputation — the desire to be well thought of, which operates just as powerfully in a congregation as in a marketplace and is almost never confessed, because it disguises itself as a proper concern for one's testimony.

The Lord identified it as an obstacle to faith itself.

How can ye believe, which receive honour one of another, and seek not the honour that cometh from God only?

JOHN 5:44

That is a startling sentence. Not *it will be difficult* but *how can ye* — the desire for human approval is presented as making faith impossible, because faith requires a valuation of things that the approval-seeker cannot afford to hold.

John records the same disease in men who did believe and would not say so.

Nevertheless among the chief rulers also many believed on him; but because of the Pharisees they did not confess him, lest they should be put out of the synagogue: for they loved the praise of men more than the praise of God.

JOHN 12:42–43

Baxter's test for this was to ask what a person is willing to be thought. Would you accept being considered foolish, unsuccessful, unspiritual, or wrong, if faithfulness required it?

He noticed that ministers and other religious workers are particularly exposed, since their standing depends on being regarded well by people whose opinion they must also correct — an arrangement almost designed to produce cowardice.

The remedy is the same as for money, and it is the cross. A man who has genuinely died has no reputation left to protect.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Answer the question honestly: what could you not bear to lose? That is where your treasure is.
2. Decide what is enough. Write down a figure or a standard, and stop moving it upwards.
3. Check whether your giving has risen in proportion to your income over the last five years. If not, notice what has.
4. Do not try to argue yourself out of the love of money. Spend the time at the cross instead.
5. Give something away this week that you will actually feel.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have called my worldliness prudence and my grasping stewardship, and nobody has ever challenged me because everyone around me does the same.

I know the world is passing. Knowing it has changed nothing.

Break its hold by the only thing strong enough. Show me Your cross until the things I have been clutching lose their shine, and until I am dead to what I have been living for.

Teach me to enjoy Your gifts without setting my heart on them, and to hold them loosely enough to give them away. Amen.

Redeeming the Time

See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise, redeeming the time, because the days are evil.

EPHESIANS 5:15–16

Baxter published around a hundred and forty books. He did it while pastoring a parish of two thousand souls, preaching twice a week, catechising fourteen families a week, carrying on a vast correspondence, engaging in most of the theological controversies of his century — and being seriously ill for practically the whole of it.

He was not a well man who worked hard. He was a man in continual pain who expected to die shortly and worked as though he might not finish the sentence.

Time as the material of life

His teaching on time follows directly from his teaching on heaven.

If this life is the brief interval in which an eternal condition is settled, then time is not a resource among others. It is the material out of which everything of lasting consequence is made, and it is issued in a quantity nobody knows.

So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom.

PSALM 90:12

Whereas ye know not what shall be on the morrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapour, that appeareth for a little time, and then vanisheth away.

JAMES 4:14

Baxter's habitual expectation of an early death was, in one sense, a mistake — he lived to seventy-six. In another sense it was the making of him, because he never once assumed he had time to spare.

Where it actually goes

He was practical about the leaks, and his list has aged remarkably well.

Idleness, which he distinguished carefully from rest. Rest is necessary and God-given; idleness is the aimless consumption of hours that produces neither refreshment nor work.

Excessive sleep, which he treated as a genuine spiritual issue and about which he was probably harder than he should have been.

Unprofitable talk, in which he included most gossip and a good deal of what passes for conversation. Baxter reckoned that many Chris-

tians spend more hours a week in idle speech than in all their religious duties combined.

Needless recreation. He allowed recreation and thought it necessary, but insisted it be treated as a means — refreshment for work — rather than an end pursued for its own sake.

Over-attention to business. Interestingly, he named this too. A man may lose his life to legitimate work as thoroughly as to idleness, and be praised for it throughout.

I must work the works of him that sent me, while it is day: the night cometh, when no man can work.

JOHN 9:4

How to redeem it

His directions are unremarkable and effective.

Know your calling, and give the bulk of your hours to it rather than to whatever presents itself. Plan the day in advance, since unplanned time is almost always lost time. Do the most important thing first, while you are able. Use the fragments — Baxter was a great believer in the odd quarter-hour, and much of his writing was done in intervals. And review at day's end, which connects this chapter to the last.

Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might; for there is no work, nor device, nor knowledge, nor wisdom, in the grave, whither thou goest.

ECCLESIASTES 9:10

An honest qualification

Here Baxter needs correcting, and it would be dishonest not to say so.

He drove himself extremely hard, and there is reason to think it cost him. His health was wretched throughout, and while much of that was constitutional, some of it was almost certainly the consequence of a regime no body could sustain. He worked when he should have stopped, and he was severe with himself in ways he would never have been with a parishioner.

His teaching can therefore be taken up in a way that damages people, and in an age that already worships productivity the danger is considerable. Two correctives are necessary.

Rest is commanded, not merely permitted. God built a day of it into the week and did not make it optional.

Come ye yourselves apart into a desert place, and rest a while: for there were many coming and going, and they had no leisure so much as to eat.

MARK 6:31

That is the Lord's instruction to workers who were genuinely busy with genuinely important work.

And our worth does not consist in our output. A believer prevented from working by illness, age or circumstance has lost nothing of his standing before God. Baxter, of all people, ought to have known this, and in his better moments he did.

Redeem the time, then — but redeem it for the right things, and remember that sleeping when you are exhausted is one of them.

Ordinary work as service

A necessary balance, since a chapter on time can leave the impression that hours spent on secular work are hours subtracted from God.

Baxter held firmly that they are not. His treatment of vocation in *A Christian Directory* covers trades, farming, commerce and household management at length, and treats them as genuine service rather than as regrettable necessities.

And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men; knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the reward of the inheritance: for ye serve the Lord Christ.

COLOSSIANS 3:23–24

Paul is addressing slaves. If the most degraded labour in the Roman world could be done as service to Christ and receive a reward from Him, then no honest work is outside the arrangement.

Baxter drew practical consequences that were unusual in his century and remain useful.

Choose a calling, where you have the choice, by its usefulness to others rather than by what it pays.

Do it well. Shoddy work by a Christian is a testimony, and not a good one.

Treat it as the place where most of your obedience will actually happen. A person converted at twenty and dying at seventy will spend perhaps ninety thousand hours at work and a small fraction of that in explicitly religious activity. If holiness cannot operate in the ninety thousand, it will not amount to much.

Not slothful in business; fervent in spirit; serving the Lord.

ROMANS 12:11

Baxter put those three together as one instruction, and so did Paul. Diligence at work, warmth of spirit, and service to Christ are not three separate departments of a life.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Track where your hours actually went last week. The gap between your estimate and the truth is the finding.
2. Plan tomorrow tonight. Unplanned time is nearly always lost time.
3. Identify your largest single leak — idleness, talk, screens, or over-work — and address that one rather than everything.
4. Use the fragments. A quarter of an hour, used regularly, adds up to more than most people's good intentions.
5. Take your rest without guilt. It is commanded, and your worth does not depend on your output.

A PRAYER

Father, You have given me a fixed number of days and I do not know the number.

Teach me to number them. Show me where my hours are going, and give me the resolve to spend them on what will matter when I stand before You.

Deliver me from idleness, and equally from the busyness that looks like faithfulness and is only fear.

And when I need to stop, let me stop without shame — knowing that You value me for what Your Son has done and not for what I produce. Amen.

Counsel for the Melancholy

*Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted in me?
hope thou in God.*

PSALM 42:11

Among the most remarkable things Baxter wrote are his treatises on what his century called melancholy — what we would call depression, anxiety and related disorders of the mind.

They are remarkable because they are three hundred years ahead of most of what was written on the subject afterwards, and because a great deal of Christian counsel since has been worse.

A disease, not a sin

Baxter's central insight is that melancholy is frequently a bodily illness that produces spiritual symptoms, and that treating the symptoms as though they were the disease makes everything worse.

The sufferer presents with religious distress. He cannot pray, cannot feel God's love, is convinced he is beyond mercy, and can produce a detailed case against himself. The natural response of a minister is to address this theologically — to reason with the doubts, urge self-examination, and press the promises.

Baxter observed that this frequently fails, and that it fails because the problem is not in the theology. The same person, restored to bodily health, generally finds his doubts have evaporated without a single argument having been answered. The doubts were a product of the condition, not its cause.

He therefore insisted that such sufferers need *physic* as well as spiritual counsel — medical treatment, taken seriously, alongside prayer. In the seventeenth century that was an unusual thing for a divine to say.

What not to do

His directions to counsellors are the most valuable part, and they cut directly against most instincts.

Do not press self-examination. This is the great error. A melancholy person turned inward will find fresh evidence against himself indefinitely, because the faculty doing the searching is the one that is disordered. Baxter's counsel was to turn such people outward — to the promises, to Christ, to other people — and to forbid the introspection that a healthy Christian should be encouraged in.

Do not leave them alone. Solitude and prolonged meditation, which he recommended warmly elsewhere in his writings, he judged actively harmful here. Company, conversation and cheerful occupation do more good.

Do not argue with every doubt. The doubts multiply faster than they can be answered, and answering them concedes the premise that the trouble is intellectual.

Do not add guilt. Telling a person that their despair is itself a sin, or evidence of weak faith, is both untrue and cruel. Baxter said that God does not break all men's hearts alike, and he meant that temperament and constitution differ, and that God knows the difference even when we do not.

What to do

His positive counsel is gentle and mostly practical.

Attend to the body first: food, sleep, exercise, fresh air, and medical help. He was insistent that the physical be addressed rather than spiritualised.

The pattern is older than Baxter. When Elijah collapsed under a juniper tree and asked God to take his life, God's first response was not a rebuke or a sermon. An angel gave him food and let him sleep, twice, before anything was said.

And as he lay and slept under a juniper tree, behold, then an angel touched him, and said unto him, Arise and eat ...because the journey is too great for thee.

1 KINGS 19:5, 7

Keep them in company and in useful employment. Give them small, achievable duties rather than large spiritual programmes.

Hold the objective promises before them, and do not require them to feel anything. Baxter's point was that a believer's safety rests on what Christ has done, not on his capacity to perceive it — and that a person who cannot feel God's love is not thereby outside it.

The Lord is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart; and saveth such as be of a contrite spirit.

PSALM 34:18

A bruised reed shall he not break, and the smoking flax shall he not quench.

ISAIAH 42:3

A word for the present day

Baxter's counsel needs no correction so much as it needs restating, but two things should be said plainly for a modern reader.

If you are suffering in this way, please seek qualified medical help. Depression and anxiety disorders are real illnesses with effective treatments, and consulting a doctor is not a failure of faith any more than

it would be for a broken bone. Baxter said as much with the medicine available to him; he would say it far more strongly now.

And if you have been told that your condition reveals a deficiency in your Christian life, that was wrong, and you may set it down. Some of the most faithful believers who have ever lived have suffered exactly this. The psalmist who wrote the verse at the head of this chapter was one of them, and he wrote it twice more in the same book because the trouble kept coming back.

If you are helping someone in this condition, the single most useful thing in Baxter is his instruction to turn them outward.

Do not ask them to examine themselves. Ask them to look at Christ, and sit with them while they cannot.

When a believer cannot pray

One particular symptom deserves separate treatment, because it distresses sufferers more than almost anything else: the inability to pray.

The person finds that prayer has become impossible. The mind will not settle, no words come, and what does come feels hollow. Since they have always been taught that prayer is the lifeline, the loss of it seems to confirm that they have been cut off.

Baxter's counsel here is gentle and entirely practical.

Use other people's words. The Psalms exist for exactly this. A person who cannot construct a prayer can read one, and the Psalter contains a considerable number written by people in this precise condition.

Out of the depths have I cried unto thee, O Lord. Lord, hear my voice.

PSALM 130:1–2

Keep it very short. A sentence is a prayer. The length of an exercise is no measure of its acceptance, and demanding an hour of a person who cannot manage a minute guarantees failure and shame.

Let others pray for you. The paralysed man in Mark 2 was carried by friends, and the text says the Lord saw *their* faith. There is no suggestion that being carried was a deficiency.

Rest on the intercession that continues without you.

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities: for we know not what we should pray for as we ought: but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered.

ROMANS 8:26

And Christ Himself is interceding, continuously, whether or not you can join in. That is the ground to stand on when nothing else holds: the prayer that secures you is not yours.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. If you are suffering in this way, see a doctor. It is not a failure of faith, and Baxter would have told you the same.
2. Stop examining yourself while you are in this condition. Turn outward to the promises instead; the inspection is making it worse.
3. If you are helping someone, attend to the body first — food, sleep, company — before addressing anything spiritual.
4. Do not argue with every doubt, and never suggest that despair is proof of weak faith.
5. Rest your safety on what Christ has done rather than on your ability to feel it. Both are true; only one of them is steady.

A PRAYER

Lord, You know that not all hearts are broken alike, and that some of Your servants carry a weight in the mind that others cannot see.

For those who cannot pray, pray in them. For those who cannot feel Your love, hold them in it anyway.

Keep me from being a cruel comforter. Let me never add guilt to a burden You are carrying with them, or press examination on a soul that needs rest and food and company.

You will not break the bruised reed. Be near, as You have promised, to those of a broken heart. Amen.

Peace Among Christians

Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.

MATTHEW 5:9

Baxter spent his life on this subject and largely failed at it, which makes him an unusually instructive teacher.

He laboured for reconciliation between the English religious parties for forty years. He drew up schemes of comprehension, wrote irenic treatises, organised associations across party lines, and served at the Savoy Conference trying to find terms broad enough to keep the moderates together. Almost none of it succeeded in his lifetime.

He also quarrelled with practically everyone, at length and in print, and knew it.

Why Christians divide

His analysis of the causes is unsentimental, and it holds up.

Pride, which he named first and repeatedly. Most controversy is not really about the question in dispute; it is about being right, being seen to be right, and not being overcome by an opponent.

For ye are yet carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men?

1 CORINTHIANS 3:3

Ignorance, in two directions. We do not know enough about the matter in hand, and we do not know enough about our opponent's actual position — we argue with a version of it we have constructed.

Party spirit, which attaches the loyalty due to Christ to a name, a tradition or a leader.

Making too many things necessary. Baxter's chief structural point: divisions multiply in proportion to the length of the list of things everyone must agree on. Shorten the list and much of the conflict disappears.

Him that is weak in the faith receive ye, but not to doubtful disputations.

ROMANS 14:1

How to conduct a disagreement

He gave practical directions, and they are usable in a church committee this month.

State your opponent's view in terms he would accept before you answer it. Baxter regarded failure here as evidence of bad faith or laziness, and most controversy as therefore illegitimate before it starts.

Distinguish the person from the position, and the position from its worst consequences. A man is not responsible for conclusions he does not draw.

Ask whether the matter is worth the cost. Baxter's rule was that the damage done by pressing a point must be weighed against the good of settling it, and that many battles are lost by winning them.

Allow that a godly man may hold what you consider mistaken. This was his strongest theme in later life — that the differences among genuinely converted people are smaller than the difference between the converted and the unconverted, and that we habitually get the proportions backwards.

But the wisdom that is from above is first pure, then peaceable, gentle, and easy to be intreated, full of mercy and good fruits, without partiality, and without hypocrisy.

JAMES 3:17

Note the order. Pure first — peace is not bought by abandoning truth — and then peaceable, gentle, and willing to be persuaded.

The limits of peace

Baxter was not advocating peace at any price, and his own life proves it. He was ejected from the church he loved rather than subscribe to terms he judged false, and he went to prison rather than be silent.

If it be possible, as much as lieth in you, live peaceably with all men.

ROMANS 12:18

Paul's two qualifications are the whole doctrine. *If it be possible* — sometimes it is not, and the fault may be entirely on the other side. *As much as lieth in you* — our responsibility extends to our own conduct and no further. A Christian is not obliged to secure peace; he is obliged not to be the one who breaks it.

The man himself

Now the honest part, and Baxter would have wanted it said.

The greatest English writer on Christian peace was, by temperament, a controversialist. He could not leave an argument alone. He answered every attack, usually at length. He wrote so much polemic that his friends begged him to stop, and his own admission late in life was that he had written too much, too fast, and too sharply.

There is something instructive in the gap. It suggests that a man may see a duty clearly, teach it well, and struggle with it all his days — and

that his teaching is not thereby invalidated. Baxter knew what peace required precisely because he had spent so long failing to achieve it.

He also, and this is the redeeming part, kept changing. The self-assessment in his autobiography records a man who had grown steadily gentler, less certain of his own judgment, and more willing to think well of those who differed. He was still arguing at the end. He was arguing differently.

The test of this chapter is not whether you value unity. It is what you do in the next disagreement.

Specifically: can you state the other person's view in terms they would accept? If not, you are not yet in a position to answer it.

The Worcestershire experiment

Baxter's most successful contribution to Christian unity was not a book or a scheme of comprehension. It was a local association of ministers, and its story is instructive.

In the early 1650s he gathered the ministers of Worcestershire — Presbyterians, Independents and men of episcopalian conviction — into a voluntary association. They agreed to co-operate in three practical things: the discipline of their congregations, the systematic catechising of their parishes, and mutual counsel.

What they did not do was resolve their differences. The question of church government, over which the nation was tearing itself apart, was deliberately left open. They simply agreed to work together on what they could agree about.

It succeeded. Other counties copied the model, and for a few years there existed in parts of England a working co-operation between parties that were at war everywhere else.

Behold, how good and how pleasant it is for brethren to dwell together in unity!

PSALM 133:1

Two lessons come out of it.

The first is that unity is more achievable locally than nationally. Baxter's grand schemes at the Savoy Conference failed completely; his county association worked. Men who know each other, whose congregations overlap, and who face the same practical problems can co-operate on a basis that abstract negotiation never reaches.

The second is that shared work unites better than shared agreement. The Worcestershire ministers did not become friends by settling their disputes. They became friends by catechising the same county, and the disputes mattered less afterwards.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. In your next disagreement, state the other position in terms its holder would accept before you reply. If you cannot, you do not yet understand it.
2. Ask of your current controversy whether the good of winning outweighs the damage of fighting. Some battles are lost by winning them.
3. Shorten your list. How many things must someone agree with you on before you can regard them as a brother?
4. Distinguish the person from the position, and the position from consequences they do not draw.
5. Where peace has failed, check whether the failure lies with you. That is the only part you are answerable for.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have argued for truth and enjoyed the arguing, and I have not always been able to tell the difference.

Show me where my convictions are really about being right. Give me the honesty to state fairly what those who differ from me actually believe.

Make me peaceable without making me hollow — pure first, and then gentle, and willing to be persuaded.

And where peace is not possible, let the fault never be mine. Amen.

Suffering and Patience

Our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:17

Baxter is worth hearing on this subject because he had unusual qualifications.

He was ill from his early twenties until his death at seventy-six, in continual pain, with a catalogue of complaints he recorded with a physician's precision. He was expelled at forty-six from the parish he had given his life to, and forbidden ever to return. He was harassed for a quarter of a century, fined, and had his goods and books seized. He buried the wife he loved. He was imprisoned at seventy, after a trial in which the Lord Chief Justice abused him from the bench and would not let his counsel speak.

He wrote about affliction as a man reporting on a country he lived in.

What suffering is for

He refused two explanations that were common then and are common now.

He would not say that suffering is meaningless — an accident in a world God does not govern. And he would not say that it is always punishment for particular sins, which is the error of Job's friends and which he had watched destroy people.

His position was that God uses affliction purposefully, and that its purposes are several.

And not only so, but we glory in tribulations also: knowing that tribulation worketh patience; and patience, experience; and experience, hope.

ROMANS 5:3–4

It weans us from the world, which no amount of preaching accomplishes. It exposes what is actually in us, which prosperity conceals. It teaches dependence. It fits a man to comfort others, since no one is much use to the suffering who has not suffered.

Who comforteth us in all our tribulation, that we may be able to comfort them which are in any trouble, by the comfort wherewith we ourselves are comforted of God.

2 CORINTHIANS 1:4

Patience is not passivity

Baxter distinguished patience carefully from resignation, apathy and stoicism.

Christian patience is not the suppression of feeling. Scripture's sufferers complain loudly — the Psalms are full of it, Job says what he thinks, and the Lord Himself asked in Gethsemane for the cup to be removed. Baxter had no patience with a piety that required people to pretend they were untroubled.

What patience means is continuing to trust and obey while the trouble lasts. It is a matter of direction rather than of temperature.

Though he slay me, yet will I trust in him.

JOB 13:15

He added a practical observation. Most people can bear a great deal if they know it will end. What breaks us is indefiniteness — not knowing how long. And this, he said, is precisely where the doctrine of heaven does its work, because it supplies the one certainty that matters: there is a term, and what lies past it is out of all proportion to what precedes it.

The arithmetic

Paul's comparison in 2 Corinthians 4 is the passage Baxter returned to most, and he insisted it be read as a sober calculation rather than a pious flourish.

Light affliction — from a man who had been flogged five times, stoned, shipwrecked and imprisoned. *For a moment* — from a man who had endured it for decades. The words are not a denial of the weight; they are a comparison, and the other term of the comparison is an eternal weight of glory.

Baxter's point was that the arithmetic works only if you can see both figures. Which brings the matter back to chapter eleven: what we call impatience is usually a failure of sight.

For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory which shall be revealed in us.

ROMANS 8:18

When it does not feel like this

An honest note, because chapters on suffering can be written by people who have not suffered and read by people who are.

Baxter did not always manage this. His writings from the worst periods contain plenty of distress, complaint and something close to despair. He lost his temper with God, and said so.

That should be a relief rather than a disappointment. The doctrine

does not require you to feel it working. A believer flat on his back, unable to pray, unable to see any purpose, and merely enduring, is not failing — he is suffering, which is what the doctrine is about.

Nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby.

HEBREWS 12:11

Afterward. The fruit is not visible during. That is stated in the text, and it is worth remembering when nothing appears to be happening.

Baxter kept his post for fifty years under conditions that would have justified retirement several times over, and produced most of his work while expecting to die. He was not made of different material. He simply kept going, which is generally what patience turns out to consist of.

Before Judge Jeffreys

Baxter's teaching on patience can be tested against a documented occasion, which is more than most writers on the subject can offer.

In May 1685 he was seventy years old, in poor health, and charged with sedition for supposed reflections on the bishops in his *Paraphrase on the New Testament*. He was tried before Lord Chief Justice Jeffreys, whose conduct on the bench is one of the more notorious episodes in English legal history.

Jeffreys abused him throughout. He called him an old rogue who had poisoned the world with his Kidderminster doctrine, mocked his appearance, refused to let his counsel present the defence, and at one point suggested he deserved to be whipped through the city.

Baxter's recorded conduct was to remain quiet, to answer briefly when permitted, and at one point to remark that he was not concerned to answer such language. He was convicted, fined a sum he could not pay, and imprisoned for some twenty-one months.

Who, when he was reviled, reviled not again; when he suffered, he threatened not; but committed himself to him that judgeth righteously.

1 PETER 2:23

Three things are worth drawing from it.

He did not pretend the treatment was just. He recorded it plainly, and his account is the reason we know what happened. Patience does not require calling wrong right.

He did not retaliate, and he had the tongue to have done so devastatingly. A man who had spent forty years in controversy chose, on the one occasion when he was personally attacked before the nation, to say almost nothing.

And he went on working. Most of his remaining output, including *Dying Thoughts*, comes from after this. The injustice did not become

the subject of the rest of his life, which is the more usual outcome and the harder thing to avoid.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name what your present trouble might be accomplishing, without pretending you can see it working.
2. Distinguish patience from pretending. You may complain to God; the Psalms do. What matters is that you keep facing Him.
3. If the indefiniteness is what is breaking you, take hold of the one thing that is definite: there is a term, and what lies past it is greater.
4. Use what you have suffered. Find one person in the same trouble and go to them.
5. When you can do nothing but endure, understand that you are not failing. The fruit comes afterward, by the text's own admission.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have asked for this to be taken away and it has not been taken away, and I do not know how long it will last.

I will not pretend to feel what I do not feel. But I will keep facing You.

Work in this what only You can work — the weaning, the dependence, the usefulness to others that I cannot yet imagine. And if I see nothing of it, let me trust the text that says the fruit comes afterward.

Hold me until it is over. It will be over. Amen.

Dying Thoughts

For I am in a strait betwixt two, having a desire to depart, and to be with Christ; which is far better.

PHILIPPIANS 1:23

In 1683, at sixty-seven, widowed and infirm, Baxter published a book of meditations on Paul's words about departing to be with Christ. He called it *Dying Thoughts*, and he wrote it, as he had written *The Saints' Everlasting Rest* thirty-six years earlier, for himself.

The two books frame his life. He wrote the first at thirty-one expecting to die within months, and the second at sixty-seven, still expecting it, and by then with rather better grounds.

Preparing before it arrives

His central practical argument is that dying well is a matter of preparation, and that preparation cannot begin when the event does.

A man who has spent fifty years avoiding the subject will not acquire, in his last fortnight, a settled mind about it. The habits of thought that carry a person through will have been formed decades before, in health, when nothing was pressing.

So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom.

PSALM 90:12

Baxter recommended the deliberate contemplation of one's own death, at intervals, as a Christian discipline — not morbidly, and not as a way of frightening oneself, but as the only realistic way of getting one's affairs, priorities and affections into proportion.

It is better to go to the house of mourning, than to go to the house of feasting: for that is the end of all men; and the living will lay it to his heart.

ECCLESIASTES 7:2

Why it is far better

Paul's phrase carried the weight of the book, and Baxter took it apart.

Far better — not merely tolerable, not merely a release. Better than the best of what we have here, including the things we most love.

He set out why, and it is a summary of everything in this book. Because sin will end. Because the struggle will end. Because we shall see Christ, whom we have loved without seeing. Because we shall understand what we have spent our lives failing to understand. Because the

church will be gathered and undivided — a point Baxter felt with unusual sharpness, having spent forty years watching it tear itself apart.

For we know that if our earthly house of this tabernacle were dissolved, we have a building of God, an house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:1

Fear, honestly treated

Baxter did not pretend that believers face death without fear, and he was notably gentle here.

He distinguished the natural shrinking of the body from the fear of God's wrath. The first is instinctive and is no more sinful than flinching from fire; the Lord Himself sweated in a garden. The second is dealt with, and if a believer is still labouring under it, the remedy is not more resolve but a clearer sight of what Christ has done.

O death, where is thy sting? ...The sting of death is sin; and the strength of sin is the law. But thanks be to God, which giveth us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:55–57

He added counsel for those attending the dying: not to press them with examination at the end, not to demand expressions of assurance from people too weak to produce them, and to speak the promises rather than ask questions. A person's safety at that hour does not rest on the state of their feelings, and it is cruel to make them think it does.

How it ended

Baxter died on the eighth of December, 1691, at seventy-six, in London.

He had been in pain most of his life and considerable pain at the end. He had outlived his wife by ten years, the parish he loved by nearly thirty, and most of the causes he had fought for. He had seen the Toleration Act pass two years earlier, which was the nearest thing to a victory he ever had.

Those with him reported that when asked how he was, he answered that he was almost well.

It is a small joke and a whole theology. He had spent fifty years telling people that this life is the sickness and the next is the recovery, and at the end he was still saying it, from the bed, to whoever asked.

I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness.

2 TIMOTHY 4:7–8

He is one of the few writers who can be trusted entirely on this subject, because he never wrote a line about heaven that he was not shortly expecting to test.

And I heard a voice from heaven saying unto me, Write, Blessed are the dead which die in the Lord.

REVELATION 14:13

There remains a rest for the people of God, and Richard Baxter went into it, having written about it for forty-four years longer than he thought he would.

Those who have gone before

There is a dimension of the Christian's hope that Baxter felt with particular force after 1681, when Margaret died and he was left alone for the last decade of his life.

The New Testament describes the church as one body which death does not divide. The believers who have died are not gone; they are elsewhere, and we are told where.

Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight ...and let us run with patience the race that is set before us.

HEBREWS 12:1

To the general assembly and church of the firstborn, which are written in heaven, and to God the Judge of all, and to the spirits of just men made perfect.

HEBREWS 12:23

Baxter took considerable comfort from the thought that the company he was going to already contained people he knew — his wife, his friends, the parishioners he had buried at Kidderminster, and the writers whose books had converted and formed him and whom he had never met.

He was careful about the limits. Scripture does not encourage us to address the dead or to imagine we can communicate with them, and he had no patience with speculation of that kind. What it does teach is that they are alive, that they are with Christ, and that the separation is temporary.

For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him ...Wherefore comfort one another with these words.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:14, 18

For the bereaved reader, that is the entire point of the doctrine, and Paul says so in as many words. It is given to be used.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Think deliberately about your own death this week — not morbidly, but long enough to see what it does to your priorities.

2. Put your affairs in order: the will, the debts, the letter you have been meaning to write, the reconciliation you have postponed.
3. Distinguish natural fear from the fear of wrath. The first is human; the second has been dealt with.
4. If you sit with the dying, speak the promises rather than asking questions. Do not require assurance from those too weak to produce it.
5. Ask what you would want to be doing at the end, and do more of it now.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have arranged my life as though it would not end, and I will not have the sense to prepare at the last minute if I have not begun now.

Teach me to number my days. Let the thought of standing before You sort out what matters from what does not, while there is still time to act on it.

Take away the sting. Whatever natural fear remains, let me not fear Your wrath, for Your Son has borne it.

And when the hour comes, let me be found where Your servant was — almost well, and nearly home. Amen.

Conclusion

*Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmoveable, always
abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your
labour is not in vain in the Lord.*

1 CORINTHIANS 15:58

Eighteen chapters can suggest that Richard Baxter taught a great many things. In one sense he did — he wrote around a hundred and forty books and had opinions on everything. But the working principle underneath is single, and it is stated in the verse above.

It is this: *eternity is real; therefore work.*

That is the whole man. The two halves of his reputation — the theologian of heaven and the model of pastoral diligence — are not two interests that happened to coexist in one person. They are cause and effect. He catechised illiterate weavers two days a week because he believed each of them would exist for ever. He wrote about the saints' rest and then behaved as though there were no time to rest at all, and there is no contradiction in that whatever.

Take away the eternity and the labour becomes fanaticism. Take away the labour and the eternity becomes sentiment. Baxter held them together, and everything else in this book follows: the urgency of his evangelism, the weight he placed on personal instruction, the seriousness about time, the household as a mission field, the refusal to divide over secondary things when the primary thing was so enormous.

The danger of this book

If you have read this far, there is a particular hazard, and it is the opposite of the one attending the other volumes in this series.

Baxter is exhausting. His standard is extremely high, his tone is urgent, and he was capable of a diligence that almost nobody can match — and did not always recognise that. A conscientious reader can finish him convinced that he has never done anything properly in his life, and be paralysed rather than moved.

That would be a misuse. Baxter wrote to rouse the complacent, not to crush the willing, and his own theology gives the corrective. A believer's acceptance rests on Christ and not on his productivity. The man who spent his life urging others to labour finished his own by observing, from bed, that he was almost well — not that he had done enough.

For he knoweth our frame; he remembereth that we are dust.

So take one thing. Not the whole programme — one thing. Fix a family worship time, or begin meeting with one person, or set twenty minutes for meditation on what is coming. Baxter's method was never grandeur; it was a modest practice sustained for years.

Two things to carry

First, the eternal weight of ordinary people. If Baxter has one gift for the modern church it is this. He looked at a weaving town of two thousand unimpressive people and saw two thousand immortal souls, and it reorganised his diary. That vision, more than any technique, is what produced the ministry everyone has admired ever since.

Second, the shortness of the list. Baxter spent forty years arguing and concluded that the things necessary to be believed are fewer and plainer than controversialists suppose, that the difference between godly Christians is smaller than we think, and that the difference between the godly and the ungodly is larger. Every generation needs to hear it and none has ever much wanted to.

A last word about the man

We have been honest about his failures.

His doctrine of justification was judged by most of his own tradition to compromise the freeness of the gospel, and chapter six sets out why the objection has force. He was contentious, and the greatest English writer on Christian peace quarrelled with almost everybody. He wrote far too much and admitted it. He drove a sick body past what it could bear and called it faithfulness. His political judgment was, by his own account, repeatedly wrong.

None of that is raised to diminish him. It is raised because he raised it about himself, at length, in an autobiography which contains one of the most honest pieces of self-assessment in the language — a man in old age listing the ways his mind had changed, and finding himself less certain, less impressed by cleverness, and slower to condemn than he had been at thirty.

That is worth more than most people's virtues. A teacher who has learned something from his own mistakes is more useful than one who never made any.

But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:7

Kidderminster remembered him for generations. The manual he dashed off for a county association of ministers is still set for theological

students three and a half centuries later. The book he wrote on what he assumed was his deathbed at thirty-one has been consoling the dying ever since.

He expected none of it. He expected to be dead by the spring.

A PRAYER

Lord, I believe in eternity and it has changed almost nothing about my week.

Give me Baxter's sight — to look at the ordinary people around me and see souls that will outlast the stars, and to let that reorder what I do with my hours.

Keep me from being crushed by what I cannot do. Let me take one thing and be faithful in it for years.

And shorten my list. Let me hold the great things firmly, the small things loosely, and every brother charitably.

I am almost well, and nearly home. Keep me at my post until then. Amen.

A Reader's Guide to Richard Baxter

*Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not
to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.*

2 TIMOTHY 2:15

Baxter presents the reader with two difficulties: there is far too much of him, and his prose is heavy going.

He published around a hundred and forty works. His sentences are long even by seventeenth-century standards, he qualifies everything, and he never uses one clause where four will serve. His friends complained about it in his lifetime.

The good news is that everything is in the public domain, that several of his best works exist in excellent modern abridgements, and that the abridgements are the right place to start. There is no virtue in struggling through an unabridged folio when a competent editor has already done the work.

Begin here

The Reformed Pastor (1656). His most useful book and the one still read. Modern abridged editions run to a couple of hundred pages and lose nothing essential. Every pastor, elder and Sunday school teacher should read it once, with the caution of chapter seven in mind.

A Call to the Unconverted (1658). Short, plain, and written for people with little education. Still usable as an evangelistic gift.

The Saints' Everlasting Rest (1650), in abridgement. The full work runs to four substantial parts; the abridgements generally preserve the description of heaven and the directions for heavenly contemplation, which are what most readers want.

On the Christian life

Dying Thoughts (1683). Meditations on Philippians 1:23, written in old age. Short and moving.

The Life of Faith. The basis of chapter eleven; on living by the unseen.

The Poor Man's Family Book. Written for households with little education, in dialogue form. A window into how he actually taught.

A Breviate of the Life of Margaret Baxter (1681). His memoir of his wife, written within weeks of her death. Not theology, and one of the most affecting things in the century — a widower's portrait of a woman

he plainly thought his better.

The great practical work

A Christian Directory (1673). An enormous manual of practical theology and cases of conscience, running to something like a million words, covering private devotion, family life, church relations and public dealings. Not to be read through. It is a reference work, and it is worth consulting on any question of Christian practice you can think of, because he almost certainly addressed it.

On melancholy

Baxter's writings on melancholy and overmuch sorrow, discussed in chapter fifteen, are scattered and less easy to obtain, but worth seeking out. They are three centuries ahead of most of what followed and remain among the wisest Christian counsel on the subject. Read them with the modern note supplied in that chapter: seek qualified medical help.

Approach with care

Aphorisms of Justification (1649) and the long train of controversial writings that followed it. This is the material discussed in chapter six. Read it only if you want to understand the debate, and read the objections alongside it.

The polemical works more generally. There are a great many, they are exhausting, and Baxter himself came to regret their number and their sharpness.

His own account

Reliquiae Baxterianae, his autobiography, published in 1696 after his death. The full text is unwieldy; the standard abridgement is far more readable and contains the famous passage on how his mind changed with age, which is the single best thing he wrote about himself.

About Baxter

Geoffrey Nuttall's *Richard Baxter* (1965) is a compact and reliable scholarly life. J. I. Packer wrote his doctoral work on Baxter's theology and returned to him repeatedly afterwards; the chapters on Baxter in *A Quest for Godliness* are the best short appreciation available, and are candid about the justification problem. N. H. Keeble has written well on Baxter as a writer and on the Nonconformist world he inhabited.

Read more than one. Baxter attracts admirers who overlook his faults and critics who overlook everything else.

Three counsels for reading him

Read the abridgements first, and without embarrassment. The editors have removed repetition, not substance.

Read him for the burden rather than the system. Where he presses beyond Scripture — and on justification he does — take the pastoral concern and leave the framework.

And read him in small quantities. Baxter is rich and heavy, and a few pages digested will do more than fifty pages endured. He would have said the same; he said it about his own writing more than once.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:21